Inside Curious Minds

Types of Unreliable Narration in Contemporary English Novels

Diplomarbeit

zur Erlangung des akademischen Grades
einer Magistra der Philosophie

an der Karl-Franzens-Universität Graz

vorgelegt von
Ines HOFER

am Institut für Anglistik
Begutachter: Ao.Univ.-Prof. Mag. Dr.phil. Martin Löschnigg

Graz, 2010

Für
meine Mama Elfi
meinen Papa Franz
meinen Bruder Thomas
meinen Bruder Daniel

Table of Contents

1. Introduction 5
2. What does unreliable narration mean? 7
3. The functions of unreliable narration 9
4. The beginnings and development of unreliable narration: a brief historical outline 10
5. Traditional perceptions 11
6. A new conception of unreliable narration 12
   6.1 *A reader who responds* 14
7. Different degrees of unreliability 14
8. Signals indicating unreliability 16
9. Textual signals 16
   9.1 Signals within the narrated world - the *mad monologist*'s perspective 17
   9.2 Signals on the level of discourse - digressions and other aspects related to content 19
   9.2.1 Deviation from conventional literary patterns 21
   9.2.2 Linguistic signals 22
   9.3 Signals related to the overall structure of the text 25
   9.3.1 The structure of perspectives 26
   9.3.2 Structural aspects such as repetitions and order/sequence of events 27
   9.3.3 Diary entries 27
   9.3.4 Paratextual signals and intertextuality 28
10. *Frames of reference* 29
   10.1 *The frame theory* 30
   10.2 *Frames* that deal with a society's model of reality 31
   10.3 Specific literary *frames* 31
11. *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* by Mark Haddon 33
   11.1 General characterisation of the 'unreliable' protagonist 33
   11.2 Christopher Boone's mind and perception of the world 34
   11.3 Christopher's social understanding and communicational abilities 36
   11.4 The unreliability of memory 43

11.5 Language and style 45
11.6 Discrepancies, paradoxes and secret messages 47
12. *Spider* by Patrick McGrath 49
12.1 General characterisation of the ‘unreliable’ protagonist 50
12.2 Psychological condition 50
12.3 Dennis’s journal 52
12.4 Solitude 54
12.5 Hilda Wilkinson 57
12.6 Paranoia and hallucinations 59
12.7 Self-destruction 61
13. *When We Were Orphans* by Kazuo Ishiguro 65
13.1 General characterisation of the ’unreliable’ protagonist 66
13.2 The unreliability of memory 71
13.3 Low level of information 74
13.4 Dream and reality 76
14. *Engleby* by Sebastian Faulks 80
14.1 General characterisation of the ‘unreliable’ protagonist 81
14.2 The social situation 82
14.3 Mike’s obsession 89
15. Conclusion 94
16. Deutsche Zusammenfassung 98
17. Bibliography 102
18. List of abbreviations 107

1. Introduction

In recent years, the literary concept of unreliable narration has become increasingly important. A considerable amount of secondary literature has been produced, ranging from the analysis of classic works to contemporary novels as well as bibliographies dedicated exclusively to novels with unreliable narrators. Some research has focused on films and film adaptations of literary works in an attempt to transfer unreliable narration to the screen. Certain literature searching machines on the World Wide Web offer devices which allow the user to look for novels containing unreliable narrators. However, being nevertheless a young category, there is still controversy and disagreement over which kind of literary characters allow this classification. Apart from that, not only would it be interesting to dedicate (more) research to literary genres such as drama or to the medium 'film', but also numerous major works in the literary landscape of novels remain disregarded by research. This concerns not only literary classics, but also narratives that were published more recently (cf. N: 33f.), which is why the analysis in this thesis concentrates on contemporary works of fiction.

In order to be able to do this, first of all, a definition of the concept of unreliable narration is provided, in which the recipient's creation of an alternative version of the story that contrasts with the depiction of the first-person narrator is of special significance. Then, a discussion of possible purposes this kind of narration has follows. In this respect, the functions pointed out are limited to the ones relevant for the specific novels that are dealt with in this thesis. Due to the fact that the unreliability of narrators already played a role in works of the 18th and 19th centuries although the term was not coined until 1961, a brief historical survey is given. It ranges from the development of first-person narratives with the simultaneous rise of notions of subjectivity to the modern conception that there is no ultimate single meaning in this world, which is still prevalent in today's social and cultural circles. Subsequently, the transition from traditional perceptions of unreliable narration as a literary category starting with Wayne C. Booth's first definition towards a new awareness marked predominantly by the narratologist Ansgar Nünning is outlined, before the thesis distinguishes between different types of unreliable narration, which

depend on issues such as how intentional the misleading portrayal of events is. In order to avoid that narrators are declared unreliable at random due to some subjective impulse on the part of the recipient, specific textual signals that characterise the discourse of numerous unreliable narrators are referred to and are essential for an objective analysis. These include aspects such as the social isolation of the narrators, their high emotional involvement and their inability to interpret events adequately due to their naïveté and are connected to the recipient's understanding of the world. Throughout this theoretical part of the thesis, references to the novels that constitute the empirical basis are presented.

The first of these is *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* (2003) by Mark Haddon. The unreliability of the main character and narrator of the novel, Christopher Boone, can be mainly ascribed to the curious way of his perception of the world due to his having Asperger's Syndrome. His naïve way of interpreting the world clashes with the perception of the other characters in the novel and makes the recipient question to what extent the picture he gives of the story can be considered accurate. In this way, the thesis provides an analysis of Christopher's social and communicational peculiarities and his unreliability of memory, followed by lexical aspects that mark unreliability as well as discrepancies his discourse gives rise to between his and the recipient's interpretation of events.

The second novel focuses on Patrick McGrath's *Spider* (1990). He can be considered unreliable inasmuch as he is a schizophrenic character that suffers from paranoia and hallucinations. He interprets dreams as if they were real incidences, which contributes to a deterioration of his precarious psychological condition that finally leads him towards self-destruction. In this destructive process, the role of solitude, which he partly compensates by confiding his thoughts to a diary, as well that of other characters, such as his father and his assumed lover, will also be considered.

Then, the analysis moves on to *When We Were Orphans* (2000) by Kazuo Ishiguro. As far as the narrator of this story is concerned, the main interest consists in the unreliability of his memory and his confusion of reality and dream, which takes the recipient into

surreal territory and thus almost to the limits of a possible analysis of the unreliability of a narrator. As his portrayal of his social condition leads to ambiguity as well, this will be another point that is paid attention to, along with his low level of information, which prevents him from giving the recipient the whole, and thus more reliable, picture of the nature of events.

Finally, this thesis deals with Sebastian Faulks's *Engleby* (2007), a story told by a narrator with a schizoid personality disorder. The reason why the recipient holds him suspect is the constant feeling that the character keeps relevant information to himself. The riddles around the murder of the girl the narrator has developed an obsession for constitute a major element of the story. As he is a loner, part of the analysis is also dedicated to his social situation and, apart from that, to the unreliability of his memory, which pervades the whole narrative.

In order to make these aspects understandable, the theoretical concepts starting with a general characterisation of unreliable narration move into the centre of attention in the upcoming part of this thesis.

Theoretical background

2. What does unreliable narration mean?

In narratology, unreliability usually describes two phenomena: firstly, the initially acclaimed nature of events turns out to be wrong in the course of the story either because information has been kept from the reader or because it is not revealed until later, so that the recipient has every right to question what actually happened (cf. Koebner 2005: 21). In Sebastian Faulks's *Engleby*, one of the books this paper's analysis is dedicated to, for example, the reader does not really suspect that the protagonist of the story, Mike Engleby, might be responsible for the death of Jennifer, a girl he is obsessed with, until much later. Similarly, initially no clues are given that he might possibly have committed two more murders. Such narrative structures can be compared to riddles as in a first

construction of the narrated world gaps remain that have to be filled retrospectively. The narrator is often mistaken or not able to distinguish between reality and imagination, hallucinations and dreams. Secondly, narrators can be characterised unreliable when they interpret events in a wrong way. Such a narrator might be a child or a *picaro* who, due to their naïve perspective, fail to understand what happens in the world of adults. Similarly, the unreliable narrator's utterances might be ironic or narrators take things easier than they are, euphemise horrible events or talk about unimportant incidents in a highly emotional way (cf. Koebner 2005: 21).

When a narrator is termed unreliable, the reader is usually confronted with a first-person narrator, who is at the same time the protagonist of the story. Their presence is explicit; unreliable narrators are mostly *overt* narrators, who interpret and comment on the story in a highly subjective way and frequently address the *implied reader*. They are often *mad monologists* whose preferred topic is they themselves. However, the signal which is probably most important is the discrepancy between what a narrator tries to convey and a second version of what happens, of which the narrator lacks awareness and which recipients can deduce by making meaning of additional implied information. This often leads to an unintended advancing exposure of the narrator's mind (cf. Nünning 1998: 6). In Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, e.g., the narrator Dennis Cleg tries to convince the reader that his father is the murderer of his mother. The narrator is unaware of the fact that the more he narrates about how his father has come to commit the crime, the more the reader does hold him, Dennis, responsible.

Occasionally, as already insinuated above, the unreliable narrator is also referred to as *mad monologist* (cf. Allrath 1998: 62). Narratives of *mad monologists* are an extreme form of unreliable, homodiegetic narration. The course of events is not linear, but centres obsessively around a certain, indirectly addressed topic (cf. Sims 1998: 109). Such an approach to events can serve different purposes.

3. The functions of unreliable narration

Usually unreliable narration does not only have one function; rather, it tends to be used for various reasons (cf. Bläß 2005: 189). There can be distinguished between three categories. The first one refers to functions related to the text. Here auto-referential functions such as the emphasis on the narrator's mind rather than on events, which can lead to a revelation of the narrator's instability, are included. Secondly, it is alluded to a group of functions related to the context, which are termed hetero-referential functions. These functions allow an author to address extratextual, culturally specific phenomena. They include notions of subjectivity and epistemological scepticism, two aspects that will be referred to later in more detail in an outline of the history of unreliable narration. A third group consists of so-called affective or appellative functions and is related to the recipient's emotional reactions. These functions include the pleasure of the construction of an alternative discourse, which has already been compared to something like the piecing together of a puzzle, an activity considered to lead to a positive feeling in the recipient. Shock and retrospective surprise moments can have a similar effect. Also the *manipulation of audience response* can be found in this group. This is a technique an author uses in order to induce the recipient to either develop sympathy for a narrator due to a higher identification potential with the *narrating I* or to distance themselves and develop a negative image because of the narrator's manipulations and distortions (cf. Bläß 2005: 194ff.).

In Haddon's novel *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*, for instance, the reader is likely to develop positive feelings towards the 15-year-old protagonist Christopher Boone due to his child-like speech and perception that suggest innocence and the feeling that it is not his fault that he behaves the way he does. After an incident, in which he is almost killed by a train because of his intention to capture his pet rat Toby, when a woman wants to make sure he is alright, he reacts in a pretty unpleasant way: "And I said, 'I've got a Swiss Army Knife and it has a saw blade and it could cut someone's fingers off.'" (Haddon. *CID*: 226) The three main clauses, connected with the linking word "and", indicate Christopher's infantile style, which makes the reader

perceive Christopher as an innocent child, who is not able to identify the good nature in the woman's approach because he simply does not know better. Furthermore, the reader forgives him his behaviour as he is aware from the very beginning that he has Asperger's Syndrome and because Christopher explains that being close to strangers makes him scared. The recipient sympathises with him even if they might disagree with certain aspects about his behaviour, such as the verbal violence in the particular utterance cited above.

In contrast to Christopher Boone, with Dennis Cleg, the protagonist in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, it is not so easy to identify with. Even if the reader sympathises with him, too, due to the general higher identification potential in a first-person narrative, as there is an awareness that he suffers from some kind of impairment also from the very beginning and because of certain amiable peculiarities in his behaviour, at times his descriptions are not very agreeable or even likely to be appalling to a majority of readers: above all the descriptions about his body, in which "material [is] slowly rotting" (McGrath. *S*: 176), which is slowly being invaded by a worm and which is inhabited by spiders as well, can be rather disagreeable: "A small pipelike apparatus, something from a plumber's toolbox, protrudes and begins urinating tiny black spiders into the bowl, where they curl up into points and float on the water. I appear to be infested; I appear to be playing host to a colony of spiders; I appear to be an *egg-bag*." (McGrath. *S*: 176f.) Even if the recipient might like spiders, I suspect that the idea of urinating the arthropods is hardly likely to be pleasant to anybody.

4. The beginnings and development of unreliable narration: a brief historical outline

Although this analysis is dedicated to the four contemporary novels *Spider* (1990), *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* (2003), *Engleby* (2007) and *When We Were Orphans* (2000), the phenomenon of unreliable narration cannot only be found in modern and postmodern works as it originates in the 18th and 19th centuries. Already authors such as Edgar Allan Poe and Daniel Defoe integrated the subjectivity and the

topic of the potential instability of narrators in their works (cf. Menhard 2009: 43). An early example frequently alluded to when narratologists address unreliable narration is Maria Edgeworth's *Castle Rackrent* (1800), in which Thady, a naïve and unsuspecting servant, lacks understanding of the events and background conditions he portrays (cf. Fludernik 2009: 27). However, Nünning (1997: 92) stresses that "[i]n the nineteenth-century British novel, unreliable narration is still very much the exception rather than the rule."

In the course of the 19th century, narrative techniques move from omniscience to more personalized mechanisms, which stress the relativity and limitations of narrative utterances. Towards the end of the 19th century – the end of the Victorian period and the beginnings of modernism – unreliable narration becomes increasingly significant (cf. Menhard 2009: 44). Nünning (1997: 93) states that "[i]n the late nineteenth and early twentieth-century novel one finds a broad range of individualized first-person narrators whose reliability the reader has reasons to suspect." This growing presence of homodiegetic narrators is accompanied by the use of narrative unreliability, questioning the illusion of a narrator reporting the truth, and spreads rapidly during the 20th century. Of course, this rising importance of unreliable narrators is connected to cultural and social developments: "changing notions of subjectivity" (Nünning 1997: 95) lead to an increased awareness of the subjective way in which individuals perceive reality, a movement that found its culmination in postmodernism (cf. Menhard 2009: 44).

5. Traditional perceptions

Despite the fact that unreliable narrators can already be found in works of the 18th and 19th centuries, the term 'unreliable narrator' was not coined until the 20th century. It was Wayne C. Booth (1983: 158ff.), who came up with it first in 1961: "[…] I have called a narrator *reliable* when he speaks for or acts in accordance with the norms of the work (which is to say, the implied author's norms), *unreliable* when he does not." According to Booth, the difference between reliable and unreliable narrators lies, above all, in the degree and type of distance between the narrator and the *implied author*'s standards.

Since Booth's creation and definition of the term *unreliability*, most narratologists have accepted this source as the only reference serving the determination of a narrator's unreliability. According to his definition, the *implied author* communicates with the *implied reader* secretly behind the narrator's back. This message determines the degree of reliability. In order to illustrate this, Chatman draws on already established models of the communicational structure of narrative texts in narratology (cf. N: 13ff.).

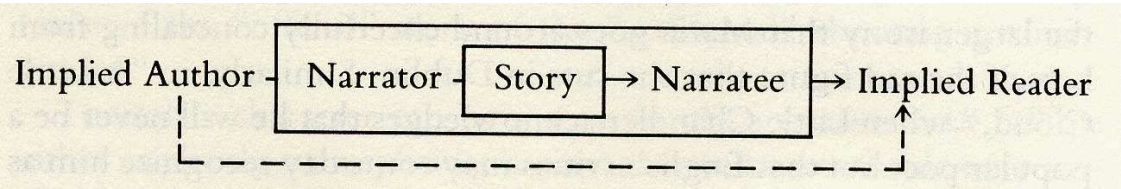


Fig.1 (Chatman 1990: 151)

There is, however, no satisfactory explanation as to how the *implied author* goes about transmitting their secret message and thus undermining the reliability of the narrator. Additionally, Booth's definition seems insofar inadequate, as the concept of the *implied author*, which is used as a reference, is a vague and unclear category itself, because it is still questionable how the norms and values of the *implied narrator* can be determined. This is presumably one of the reasons why there appears to be a rising number of narratologists who acknowledge the inadequacy of the concept of the *implied author*. One of them is Nünning (1998: 10ff.), who considers dismissing the doubtful concept entirely.

6. A new conception of unreliable narration

In order to describe the processes that characterise unreliable narration, the narratologist suggests going back to the concept of *dramatic irony*, which occurs when "the internal and external communication systems interfere with each other and overlap" (Pfister 1977: 56). Thus it is a pragmatic phenomenon that cannot be described as exclusively text-immanent, as it is the case in Booth's definition: a narrator is unreliable when the discrepancy between the values and intentions of the narrator and the state of knowledge

of the *real*, and not the *implied, reader* results in *dramatic irony*. As soon as the reader has discovered the narrator's lack of reliability with the help of certain textual signals, the narrator's utterances obtain an unintended additional meaning, of which they are unaware, due to the reader's higher level of knowledge (cf. N :17). When Christopher Boone in *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*, for instance, is paranoid about his father finding and murdering him, the recipient is aware - due to their higher level of knowledge - that Christopher's dad is not dangerous but just being protective over his son. The *dramatic irony* here lies in the fact that the recipient has information at their disposal that Christopher is unaware of due to his naïve and therefore limited perspective.

Nünning (1998: 17) then proposes modifying Booth's definition and relates the unreliable narrator's perspective to the value system of the whole text instead of relating it to the *implied author's:* a narrator is unreliable when their perspective contradicts the values and norms of the whole narrative.

Linked to the concept of *dramatic irony* is the discrepancy between the narrator's explicit utterances about themselves and other characters and the implicit self-characterisation taking place at the same time, which assumes a special significance when it comes to unreliable narration. Especially talkative and mad monologists cannot avoid revealing their attitudes, norms, weaknesses and peculiarities.

Thus unreliable narration means that readers gain information from what the narrator says on two levels: first of all, they are confronted with the facts of the story. Usually the narrators are conscious of them. Then, however, there is also a level of implicit additional information the narrator is unaware of, a second version of the story, so to speak. This leads to a shift of the reader's attention from the facts of the story to the narrator, who allows the reader to gain insight into their often highly idiosyncratic perspectives. Sometimes, though, it is difficult to determine whether fictional utterances are facts or an unintended exposure of the narrator's self (cf. N: 18f.) and the recipient is challenged even more. In *Engleby*, for example, when Mike talks to the police, he introduces the idea

that, besides Jennifer, he might have murdered an old school-mate, namely Baynes, too: "I was wondering whether this would be a good moment to own up to having killed old Baynes as well." (Faulks. *Engleby:* 269) The recipient, however, is frequently being told about Mike's memory loss and also a psychiatrist utters his doubts about Mike being the murderer. Therefore, it is not totally clear if it is a fact that Mike is responsible for Baynes's death or whether the references to his being the murderer only serve to illustrate the confusion and uncertainties in Mike's mind.

6.1 *A reader who responds*

From this brief description of a new conception of unreliable narration, one can already guess the central role the reader plays in this process: instead of passively adopting the narrator's perception of reality, the actual reader is asked to participate actively in the construction of an alternative meaning. The confrontation with multiple perspectives challenges this actual reader even more as their mind constitutes the central point where all the threads come together (cf. Menhard 2009: 48). The contradictions and discrepancies created by unreliable narration are dissolved through the *naturalization* of a text, a process that deals with the way a reader reads and interprets a text. *Naturalization* is of special significance with this type of narration, as it "account[s] for readers' interpretative strategies when confronting textual or semantic inconsistencies." (cf. Fludernik 1996: 31) Once the reader has spotted such incongruities, however, it is not always clear whether these are sufficient to allow for a narrator to be termed unreliable. In this respect, it might be helpful to distinguish between different degrees of unreliability.

7. Different degrees of unreliability

"Many texts make it difficult to decide whether the narrator is reliable or unreliable, and if unreliable – to what extent." (Rimmon-Kenan 1983: 103) Since the development of the term 'unreliability', various narratologists have tried to differentiate and classify the concept further (cf. Menhard 2009: 17). Rimmon-Kenan (1983: 100) states that there are

"different degrees of unreliability". In addition to these, also intentionality plays a role. Depending on how intentional the narrator's manipulations and delusions are, he distinguishes between *fallible* and *untrustworthy* narrators: whereas a *fallible* narrator is not aware of their distorted presentation of the narrated events, the *untrustworthy* narrator deludes the recipient on purpose (cf. Olson 2003: 93ff.).

Apart from the distinction between *fallible* and *untrustworthy* narrators, there is also another way to distinguish between different unreliable narrators: there are various types of unreliable narrators, depending on what is unreliable about their discourse. Whereas a narrator might be reliable in terms of the report of events, their evaluations might be questionable (cf. Rimmon-Kenan 1983: 101). In order to differentiate between these two aspects, Phelan/Martin (1999: 94) distinguish between "unreliable reporting […] along the axis of facts/events" and "unreliable evaluating […] along the axis of ethics/evaluation". A third category, "unreliable reading", "occurs along the axis of knowledge/perception".

Even if Menhard (2009: 39) recognises that such differentiations admit more precision in terms of the definition of unreliability, she attributes a superficial character to these categories as in the end they do not make a difference in the reconstruction of actual events. However, it could be thought that she underestimates the importance of a differentiation as it is not only important to figure out what really happened but it is also essential to describe the unreliable narrator's character traits in order to be able to address the functions of unreliable relation, which allows an approach to potential meanings of a text. In order to determine these functions, the degree of unreliability might be of interest. In Kazuo Ishiguro's *When We Were Orphans*, e.g., unreliable narration serves to address the subjectivity of how reality is perceived and the deconstruction of conventional concepts of truth (cf. Menhard 2009: 203). This function is directly related to the type of unreliable narrator, whose discourse gives rise to doubt unintentionally. Instead of one final truth that is kept from the reader on purpose, there might be diverse truths depending on how reality is perceived by different subjects. If the narrator deluded the reader intentionally, the effect would be quite different: there would be only one truth the

narrator tries to keep from the recipient. This is why a meaningful differentiation of the concept of unreliable narration can be very helpful. In order to determine the degree of unreliability, certain signals serve as indicators.

8. Signals indicating unreliability

Since the term unreliable narration was defined, not only conceptual problems but also imprecision in terms of methodology have arisen. Thus, in one of his analyses, Chatman (1978: 233) contents himself with the vague indication that "by ´reading out,´ between the lines, […] the events and existents could not have been ´like that,´ and so [he] holds the narrator suspect." However, in research, it cannot be left to intuition to determine whether a narrator is reliable or not, but it is necessary to make use of a set of systematic, reliable criteria that permit an intersubjective interpretation. In order to systematise signals that indicate a lack of reliability, it is advisable to distinguish between textual signals and extratextual or contextual *frames of reference*.

Textual signals are formal and thematic aspects of a narrative, which allow the questioning of a narrator's reliability without referring to the world outside the text. By way of contrast, extratextual or contextual *frames* deal with discrepancies between the fictitious world and the reader's idea of reality (cf. N: 15ff.).

9. Textual signals

Textual signals can be divided into three categories, based on the levels of communication within a narrative text: first of all, there are signals within the narrated world. Secondly, linguistic signals and signals with regards to content can be located on the level of discourse or narrative transmission. And finally, there are signals related to the level of the overall structure of a text (cf. A: 60).

9.1 Signals within the narrated world - the *mad monologist*'s perspective

One of the most important signals for unreliable narration is the increased focus on the psychological disposition of the unreliable narrator, who often seems impaired in their relationship to the outer world and in their communicational abilities. They are described as lonely and introverted social outsiders, longing for appreciation. Unreliable narrators are insecure about how to behave adequately and feel observed by their environment (cf. A: 62f.). Dennis Cleg in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, for example, is constantly paranoid about eyes watching him. In one incident, after he has been released from Ganderhill, the psychiatric hospital he has spent 20 years in, he states during his ride on a bus to London: "Immediately I felt the eyes of the women on me, their heads inclining toward one another, the murmuring, the stifled laughter, the muffled snorts of scorn." (McGrath. *S:* 200)

Partly the narrators are aware of their abnormal behaviour or perceptions (cf. A: 63). The autistic teenager Christopher Boone in Mark Haddon's novel, e.g., is conscious about them to a certain degree, as he often tries to figure out how to behave according to the expectations of society. When, at the train station, he is asked if everything is ok, he is not sure about the appropriate answer: "I looked at him [the policeman] and I thought for a bit so that I would answer the question correctly and I said, 'No.'" (Haddon. *CID:* 184)

Other narrators, by contrast, overestimate themselves, e.g. in their self-perception. This overestimation, though, can be corrected or put into perspective through dialogues between the narrator and the other characters as well as through facial expressions and gestures, which reveal perspectives in an implicit way (cf. A: 63). In Kazuo Ishiguro's novel *When We Were Orphans*, for example, the narrator Christopher Banks describes himself as well integrated in school, whereas James Osbourne, an old schoolfriend he meets, makes a comment about his having been "an odd bird" (Ishiguro. *O*: 5). The narrator's subsequent pondering about the remark and his simultaneous insisting that he has not given much thought to it (cf. Ishiguro 2000: 11) lead to the impression that his schoolfriend's perception is more reliable. In this way, the recipient receives signals

which show that the narrator's perceptions are subjective and that there are alternative ways of interpreting the events taking place (cf. A: 64).

The semantics of space can implicitly give information about the unreliable narrator's perspective as the descriptions of surroundings frequently reflect their perceptions and feelings. Thus the inner disability to communicate is often reflected in the outer isolation of the character.

Above all, it is often narrators with a moral deficit who are highly perceptive and whose norm and value systems deviate from common views on what is considered to be 'normal'. Allrath (1998: 64), though, states that it depends on the recipient's individual conceptions of 'normality' whether certain protagonists are considered *mad monologists* and mentions the narrator Stevens in Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Remains of the Day* (1989) as an example. The same holds true for Ishiguro's protagonist Christopher Banks in *When We Were Orphans.* In the empirical part of this paper a more detailed analysis of why Christopher Banks might be considered unreliable will be provided. In any case, though, a narrator's reliability can decrease due to a high degree of emotional involvement or because of a low level of information, which lead to an increased subjective distortion of a perspective (cf. A: 64).

Other cases are more obvious and narrators are declared unreliable e.g. due to common conceptions of madness. Mad narrators are unable to distinguish between dream and reality, suffer from hallucinations or paranoia or feel threatened by other characters (cf. A: 64). Not only does this apply to Christopher Boone in *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*, but also to Dennis Cleg in *Spider*, for instance, who are both preoccupied with the idea that their fathers try to murder them. The psychological dispositions of unreliable narrators range from slight confusion to pathological cognitive impairment. The perception of narrators suffering from an impairment of epistemic ability is frequently displaced. They imagine sensory perceptions or voices, such as in Patrick McGrath's *Spider,* or overestimate their perceptual awareness. Sometimes they describe perceptions by relating to an inadequate sense organ.

In some cases, it is interesting to observe the low tension between the *narrating I* and the narrator's earlier self due to the unreliable narrator's intense emotional involvement. There are literary works, in which narrators constantly jump from their role as a narrator to their role as a character and not only the distance in terms of time but also the moral distance is barely noticeable (cf. A: 64f.). The mental state of the adult Dennis Cleg in *Spider*, for example, does not differ much from Dennis's mental condition as a child or teenager. The *narrating I* is still as confused as the *experiencing I* and it lacks the same awareness that Dennis himself – and not his father – is responsible for his mother's death. Similarly, the narrator's mind is still at unease, when he thinks about the past: "That shed - what a shudder it still arouses in me, the very thought of the place!" (McGrath. *S:* 32) The exclamation mark at the end of the utterance intensifies the effect of a still troubled mind. In this respect, he is a static character. By way of contrast, in some works the narrator's increased awareness leads to a growing moral distance between the two roles (cf. A: 65). In *When We Were Orphans*, for example, the reader gets the impression that, in contrast to *Spider*, the narrator Christopher Banks does grow to a certain degree, as he recognises that he might have been wrong about his encounter with his childhood friend Akira. Sometimes the description of events in the past helps the reader to psychologically *naturalize* the narrator's behaviour, so that memories of formative events in the protagonist's childhood can be used in order to explain the narrator's problematic perspective (cf. A: 65).

9.2 Signals on the level of discourse - digressions and other aspects related to content

As far as the analysis of the contents of a narrator's utterances on the level of narrative transmission is concerned, it is important to mention that unreliable narrators tend to digress. Often in these digressions the narrator's deficits are clearly revealed. In many cases one of these deficits consists in the fixation of the narrators on themselves. Their views of reality are in the centre and their own experiences and opinions, through which they try to justify their behaviour, are stressed. Also when it comes to describing other

characters, the narrators actually reveal more about themselves. Sometimes they even project parts of their personality onto another character.

In terms of content, there are also other signals suggesting unreliable narration. When narrators contradict themselves, when they talk about their madness or when they reflect on their ability to recall events, the reader receives indications for possible deficits and discrepancies in the perspectives of the narrators (cf. A: 66). The frequent doubt about the accuracy of his memories the narrator utters in *When We Were Orphans*, for example, leads to the recipient's questioning the reliability of the narrator's utterances.

When narrators make an explicit utterance, which is contradicted by implicit information, or when they evaluate their own or other characters' behaviour in a way that contradicts their narration, their lack of understanding is revealed. Most of the *mad monologists* become involved in contradictions when they describe and evaluate their own behaviour (cf. A: 66). When Mike Engleby in Sebastian Faulks's novel assures that he has never experienced loneliness, but at the same time points out that the advantage of working in journalism is that "[p]eople are more or less compelled to talk to you, and this can be helpful if you don't have that many close friends" (Faulks. *E:* 180), it hardly seems convincing that he is not longing for more contact with human beings.

Besides, the recipient receives information about the narrator's perspective through the selection of the topics dealt with by the narrator. One of these topics can be the explicit address of the narrator's own madness. As far as madness is concerned, the narrator's tendency to contradict the opinions of other characters or of the *implied reader* in case they declare them mad is obvious in numerous unreliable narratives. The narrator's subjective insistence on their mental health might be exactly what makes the recipient question their sanity. By asking "But why will you say that I am mad?" in Edgar Allan Poe's *The Tell-Tale Heart*, the narrator deals with madness explicitly. Due to his constant denial of the *implied reader*'s assumption that he is mad, the recipient's impression that the narrator actually does suffer from mental illness is confirmed.

Also the narrator's explicit auto-referential reflections about his ability to recall events can serve as a signal for the reader. As memories are an active reconstruction of the past conditioned by present circumstances, these reflections give the reader information about the narrator's perspective at the time of the narration. Sometimes distortions occur as a consequence of a retrospective creation of meaning. Narrators may be aware of these distortions and excuse their partly contradictory descriptions and explain unconnected memories retrospectively. When a narrator doubts the accuracy of memories and when the access to the present seems to have been distorted, subjectivity is increased and the reliability of memories is even more undermined. A very clear example for such vague and doubtful memories can be found in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, in which the narrator claims that he is able to recall events in the distant past, but that he has difficulties remembering events that have just happened. As he also seems to have only a vague grasp of the present, the doubt about his reliability concerning the portrayal of events that happened when he was an adolescent is justifiable.

9.2.1 Deviation from conventional literary patterns

Besides aspects concerning the content of narration, deviations from conventional literary patterns can reduce a narrator's reliability (cf. A: 67f.). Sometimes, for example, the events make it impossible for a narration to proceed and still, this is what happens: a narrator might continue with their narration even if they die in the course of action. Similarly, when a narrator is not able to make utterances due to some kind of impairment, but still transmits a narration, reliability is reduced.

Dennis Cleg, the narrator in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, for example, violates literary conventions, inasmuch as he informs the recipient about his father's thoughts and feelings, even if he is a homodiegetic and thus cognitively limited character, who does not have access to other characters' conscience and emotions. Allrath (1998: 69) points out that the description of events such as how Hilda and his father have met in a bar seems to consist of speculations only, as at this point of time the narrator mentions explicitly that he has been in his bedroom ("From my bedroom window [..] I'd see them

[his parents] leave through the back door" [McGrath. *S:* 26]). The violation of narrative conventions can be noticed even more when Dennis Cleg refers to his father's feelings for Hilda. The reflections and emotions he describes as well as the statement, that in his imagination, his father has practiced sex with her "more than once" (McGrath. *S:* 33) suggest that the narrator projects his own fantasies and desires onto his father. Apart from that, the narrator's allusion that he has not met Hilda until later and thus has "little to guide [him] but [his] intuition" (McGrath. *S:* 38) reveals that his descriptions consist of mere speculation (cf. A: 69).

9.2.2 Linguistic signals

Moreover, the language of *mad monologists* gives numerous clues serving the evaluation of the degree of reliability as it reveals aspects about the narrator's psychological disposition.

Mind-style

Linguistic signals include the concept of mind-style, which refers to the interrelation between thoughts and speech (cf. Nischik 1991: 109). Fowler (1977: 103) defines the concept as "any distinctive linguistic presentation of an individual mental self." Mind-style transmits implicit meanings that reveal a narrator's attitudes and mental states by means of linguistic features such as word-choice and the structure of sentences (cf. Nischik 1991: 4). Analogically to a real people, literary characters characterise themselves due to the choice of linguistic features. This choice underlines certain aspects and mirrors individual thought and perception patterns of the specified character. When it comes to mind-style, metaphors are of special interest, as they are a very potent device of cognition, which often concentrate on the grotesque aspects of existence. In the same way, in which a narrator's interpretations of specific experiences and views of the world can characterise themselves, do symbols, similes and metaphors reveal important aspects about the narrator's character (cf. Sims 1998: 110f.).

The use of *leitmotif* words, sentences or phrases

Often single words or sentences assume a specific meaning so that they function as *leitmotif* and thus gain significant meaning as a projection area for the narrator's desires and anxieties. Due to the frequent use of certain terms they gain the recipient's attention. As Allrath (1998: 72) observes, in Patrick McGrath's *Spider,* for example, the narrator frequently refers to "people" (9) or "creatures in the attic" (McGrath. *S:* 151), which assumes a key function in the narrative. In order to make sense of this *leitmotif* and interpret it as an indication for the narrator's abnormal mental state, the reader has to go back to the colloquial use of the word "attic" as a metaphor for the human brain. Interestingly enough, the narrator always hears this noise in the attic at night, when he remembers the murder of his [mother], which has caused his stay in an institution for the mentally ill.

Reader address

Among other important linguistic features is the mode and frequency of reader address. Even if the narrators are referred to as monologists, the fictitious reader or *narratee* plays an important part in every narrative text. Often the narrator's address to the *narratee* serve their need to justify their own behaviour and thus to catch the reader's attention. The fictitious reader becomes involved through phatic phrases, implicit questions and hypotheses as well as appellatives. It might occur that a narrator flatters the fictitious reader, assumes similarities between their own and the *narratee*'s behaviour or the narrator even tries to bribe the *narratee* (cf. A: 70f.).

Even if the *narratee*'s perspective can usually only be deduced implicitly from the narrator's reactions to their questions or comments, it serves the recipient to receive corrections of the *mad monologist*'s subjective perceptions and interpretations. In numerous narrative texts social workers or psychiatrists assume the role of the *narratee*. A total withdrawal of the *narratee* can indicate distortions of the narrator's perspective. Thus a diary – a 'personified piece of paper' (Zimmermann 1995: 38), for example, can

assume the role of a fictitious addressee. In that case, it is often the deviation from the norms of the relationship between the narrator and their diary rather than the content that reveals the narrator's existential loneliness and distortions. As the narrator might not have a trustworthy listener, they confide their thoughts and feelings to their diary. This emphasises their unfulfilled desire to communicate (cf. A: 71). The role of diaries will be referred to in more detail later in this paper, after dealing with some more linguistic features.

Syntactic level

On the syntactic level fragmentary parts of sentences as well as the accumulation of interjections indicate a high degree of emotional involvement and thus a narrator's possible unreliability. Frequent exclamations and the emphasis or lack of syntactic connexions between the fragmented sentences, emphasised typographically by the use of dashes, intensify this effect. Language that seems hesitant and that involves constant reformulations can indicate a narrator's insecurity towards situations as well as their limited narrative competence or limited access to information.

Lexical indicators

Moreover, the choice of words can indicate a high degree of emotional involvement and a problematic norm and value system. Here, it is evaluative expressions that play a significant role, i.e. expressions a speaker uses in order to comment and evaluate events, which give insight into his emotional attitude to what is happening. On the one hand, expressions that suggest increased emotional involvement can indicate distortions in the presentation of events (cf. A: 70). Thus, in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, the narrator's hatred towards his father becomes clear due to the terms he uses in order to characterise him: adjectives such as "dead", "stinking" and "rotten" (McGrath. *S:* 44) as well as certain phrases used to describe his father's feelings after he has murdered his wife make the recipient, even if not until they start considering the possibility that the narrator might accuse an innocent man, undermine the narrator's evaluative adequacy.

On the other hand, there are emotionless, emotionally distanced and casual styles that can allude to deficits in the narrator's perspective (cf. A: 71). When Christopher Boone in *CID*, for example, finds out that his father has lied to him about his mother's death and, as a consequence, decides to live with somebody else than his father, he goes through his options in a strikingly factual way. He compares them to a maths exam, in which "you look at all the questions and you decide which ones you are going to do and which ones you are not going to do and [in which] you cross out all the ones which you are not going to do" (Haddon. *CID:* 162). This comparison and the mind map he draws in his head underline his logical way of thinking and intensify the reader's impression of an emotionally distanced style. The fact that he has just found out that his mother is still alive does not appear to have much impact on him. He only seems to be troubled that his father might be dangerous and, consequently, murder him and that he has to go somewhere on his own. Unlike the language he uses, his behaviour is more emotional than factual. Only from the way he behaves – he vomits all over his bed and his mind does not function as it should – can the recipient deduce that his findings do have a huge impact on him.

In addition, other lexical indicators can stress the narrator's problematic norm and value system. The frequent use of euphemisms in the speech of a narrator indicates a kind of suppression of reality. Allrath (1998: 71) highlights that in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, for instance, the narrator euphemistically circumscribes his stay in an institution for the mentally handicapped as "years [he has] spent in Canada" (McGrath. *S*: 91).

9.3 Signals related to the overall structure of the text

As the single aspects of the fictional world and of narrative transmission are not isolated from each other, but part of a structure, it is necessary to include as well structural relations when it comes to analyzing the signals in unreliable narratives.

9.3.1 The structure of perspectives

Structural signals can give important information about the unreliability of narrators. Multiple perspectives, though, sometimes make it difficult to figure out 'what really happened', as a number of texts lack a vanishing point where all the threads of the individual perspectives come together. The failure of communication between the characters and, consequently, the lack of intersubjectivity draw the recipient's attention to the fact that individual perceptions of reality are subjective. Single perceptions, interpretations and values are loose and it is not possible to connect them to a unified image. As there is no omniscient entity that can be relied on, it is the recipient's task to construe overlaps and deviations between the different models of reality, without being guided by the analyses and comments of a narrator who does not take part in the story. The contrasts between an individual's and the other characters' viewpoints stress the distortion of the isolated perspective. The subjectivity of the single points of view cannot be figured out by the recipient until the course of the reading process allows setting them into contrast. In a multiperspectivistic text, the author can privilege certain constructs of reality or create an especially unreliable perspective. The subjective distortions might be due to a narrator's intensive emotional involvement as well as their limited access to information. Several of the events might be retold by different speakers. The degree of contrasts between the perceptions and evaluations ranges from minor modifications to totally contrary utterances. These contrasts are revealed by the interaction between the individuals on the level of the overall structure of the text (cf. A: 73ff.). In Mc Grath's novel, for example, at first the reader is confronted with Dennis's perspective according to which his father has murdered his mother. Later, however, another viewpoint is added, when Ernie Ratcliff, the barman of the Dog and Beggar explains that it was Dennis himself who killed her. Thus, Dennis's way of portraying events has turned out to be a delusion. To the recipient, the barman's explanation is more trustworthy than the distorted perceptions of the schizophrenic narrator Dennis, who has spent a major part of his life in a psychiatric hospital and who tells his story in a desperate attempt to make sense of events but fails to do so.

9.3.2 Structural aspects such as repetitions and order/sequence of events

Besides the structure of perspectives, there are other structural aspects that influence the reception of a text as unreliable, such as the unmotivated repetition of individual utterances. Repeated utterances are supposed to emphasise the potential deficits of a perspective. Also the order of the information given about the characters can determine the way a text influences the reader. Due to the construction of explanatory hypotheses within the framework of *naturalization*, the information given at the beginning as well as meta textual pre-information assume a central position, as the creation of *frames of reference* is based on them and as they construe the preliminary understanding of the text. Thus Spider's imagination of activities in the attic indicates a distorted perception and shapes the image the reader construes right from the very beginning. Even if the order of events alone cannot indicate unreliability, it still influences the reception and it can intensify other signals (cf. A: 74f.).

9.3.3 Diary entries

Diary entries are textual elements that are part of the structure of perspectives and facilitate the occurrence of unreliability. They are prone to a subjective, distorted representation and characterised by a high degree of personalisation and intimacy, as there is usually no addressee. This is why self-revelation rather than self-presentation takes place, which implies that the narrator usually has no intention of deluding the reader. Already the typical 'closing' of a diary indicates the extreme privacy of this narrative form. The diary allows a writer to reflect and to write down their memories. Thus the reader gains access to the narrator's interior. Due to the emphasis on the mind, diaries function like a mirror of the narrator's psyche. Often narrators are preoccupied with writing down their experiences and thoughts and attempt to interpret themselves and their environment and thus to justify their behaviour. A possible failure to understand and interpret events as well as perceptions of the self may question the narrator's reliability. As already mentioned above, in McGrath's Spider, for example, the narrator writes a

journal in order to make sense of what has happened. Due to his lack of understanding, however, he fails to do so. A tendency according to which numerous mentally ill, morally abnormal and socially isolated narrators present parts of their story in the form of a diary can be observed. Usually events are described with little distance between the act of writing and the point of time when they have taken place (cf. Menhard 2009: 90ff.).

9.3.4 Paratextual signals and intertextuality

Moreover, it should be added that paratexts such as titles, guiding concepts, prefaces and epilogues as well as chapter headings can give first indications of the lack of a narrator's reliability. Such meta textual information can inform the reader about central characters or themes before they start reading. Significant titles, which address madness by using metonymy, for example, and guiding concepts for which quotations or proverbs have been chosen can be valuable information (cf. A: 75).

As far as the functions of titles as signals for unreliable narration are concerned, it is necessary to distinguish between titles whose meanings can be understood without the context and those of which the reader makes sense during the reading process. When the title, for example, already alludes to the psychopathological traits of the protagonist or to the tradition of the gothic novel, which often integrates themes such as madness and the uncanny, its meaning might be understood without context. On the other hand, a title might only gain its significance in the context of the novel. Not until the actual reading process does the recipient start to interpret the title as an allusion to the narrator's impairment (cf. A: 75f.). The title "Spider", for instance, only gains its connexion to unreliability in the context of the novel, when it becomes obvious that Spider is one of Dennis's multiple personalities.

Also guiding principles allow the distinction between two categories of signals. The first category alludes to the distorted perspective of a protagonist, whereas items in the second category only gain their meaning from the intertextual reference to other literary works, often narrated by *mad monologists* as well. The guiding principle in Patrick McGrath's

Spider, for instance, shows an intertextual relation to P.B. Shelley's poem *Ozymandias*, which, as Allrath (1998: 76) observes, brings forward a dramatic irony resulting from the contrast between the overestimation of the title figure and the weather-beaten tablet bearing the inscription: "My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:/Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!" (McGrath. *S*)

Intertextual references, e.g. to a protagonist's name or to structural *frames*, however, cannot only be found in guiding principles, titles and prefaces but also in aspects within the narrated world. An example for such a textual reference is the interrelation between Clegg, the narrator in John Fowles's *The Collector*, and Cleg in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, which refers to the distortion of *Spider*'s perspective (cf. A: 77).

Textual signals, such as the structure of perspectives, linguistic features and all the other textual aspects that have been mentioned so far, can lead to a reader's questioning the narrator's reliability - above all if various of them occur frequently. Within a cognitive theory of unreliable narration textual signals alone, however, are not sufficient in order to declare a narrator unreliable. In the end, it is up to the reader how they resolve text internal contradictions in the course of the process of reception by *naturalizing* the text and by bringing it in line with culturally pre-formed models and schemes or so-called *frames of reference* (cf. N: 28f.).

10. *Frames of reference*

In order to determine unreliability, it is necessary to refer to frames used consciously or unconsciously to question the narrator's reliability. It is essential to relate text-immanent aspects to features outside the narrative in order to be able to 'measure' how reliable a narrator is (cf. N: 19). This means that unreliable narration can be considered an interactional phenomenon, which requires *a reader who responds* to take their world knowledge and their value and norm system into account (cf. N: 22-23). Therefore, the reader assumes an active role. They have to react to a narrator's contradictions and inacceptable utterances, reinterpret and constantly restructure what has been

communicated (cf. Busch 1998: 42). The assumptions and knowledge a reader has about the world can be considered as important as the information found in the text. Whether a narrator is considered reliable or not, thus, also depends on to which extent the narrator's and the reader's perceptions of reality overlap (cf. N: 25).

10.1 *The frame theory*

Together with textual signals, above all, extratextual reference to a society's perception of reality and its understanding of normality is of interest. However, instead of talking about a society's general perception of reality it is a good idea to distinguish between different *frames of reference* within the *frame theory* (cf. N: 29).

Frames of reference are considered the smallest units of the semantic integration of meanings. The reader develops *frames* out of all the information in a text. Once a *frame* is established, it serves as a criterion for the evaluation of the information that follows in the reception process. Utterances that do not fit into relevant *frames* can be interpreted as utterances made by an unreliable narrator. These *frames* are based on the text and together they form an *internal field of reference.* This runs parallel to reality, i.e. fictional events as well as situations and thought patterns can be transferred to reality (cf. Busch 1998: 42). Reality is located in an *external field of reference,* which accounts for *frames* outside the text, dealing with the knowledge a reader has of the world. This includes historical, philosophical and ideological knowledge as well as what the reader knows about "human nature" and "other texts" (Hrushovski 1984: 243).

Contextual *frameworks* can be divided into two main groups. Whereas the first one integrates *frames of reference* which deal with a society's model of reality, the second group contains specific literary *frames of reference* (cf. N: 29).

10.2 *Frames* that deal with a society's model of reality

Frames belonging to this group rely on the assumption that the fictitious world is compatible with the real world. If a narrator's comments or interpretations deviate from the reader's model of reality, they can question the narrator's reliability. Such *frames* are:

- General knowledge of the world
- The historical and cultural model of reality
- Explicit and implicit theories about personality as well as accepted conceptions concerning psychological normality
- Moral and ethical aspects that constitute a society's value and norm system
- Individual value and norm systems, the perspective and presuppositions of the reader (cf. N: 29f.)

10.3 Specific literary *frames*

Also the second group dealing with literary *frames* plays a major role as far as unreliable narrators are concerned. It is based on the knowledge a recipient has about literature (cf. N: 30): "The experienced reader of literature brings to the text a set of schemata learned from previous literary reading experience." (Harker 1989: 473) Also in this category a specification of diverse *frames of reference* is possible:

- General literary conventions
- Conventions of different genres
- Intertextual *frames of reference*, i.e. references to specific pre-texts
- Stereotypical models of literary characters
- The value and norm system the reader has developed of the text

The textual signals mentioned above gain their significance because they are related to contextual *frames*, for instance, when contradictory statements in the text are interpreted as unreliable due to psychological knowledge or moral standards (cf. N: 30f.). When

McGrath's narrator refers to the smell of gas surrounding him, the recipient doubts whether it is really there or just present in his imagination, because of the relation they establish to their psychological knowledge about schizophrenia, for example. Similarly, in an example mentioned earlier in this paper, the textual signal of the first-person narrator Dennis reporting about his father's feelings is connected to the recipient's extratextual knowledge about a specific literary convention, according to which first-person-narrators only have limited access to other character's feelings.

Book analyses

11. *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* by Mark Haddon

Mark Haddon, the author of *CID*, was born in Northampton in 1962. After his graduation from Oxford, he studied English Literature in Edinburgh. He had various jobs (cf. Holcombe 2004), among which there was his work with children with disabilities, such as autism. However, according to the author, they suffered from a much severer form than the main character of *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*. Despite the fact that disability is a topic that occurs in some of his works, it is not so much the illness itself but rather how the characters *perceive* the world because of their impairment that is of interest to the author. Maybe this is also one of the reasons why Haddon refrains from using the term 'autism' in the novel (cf. Weich 2003).

The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time is a story told by 15-year-old Christopher John Francis Boone, a character with Asperger's Syndrome, who is utterly talented in maths and science but with a lack of social understanding. When one day, he finds Mrs. Shear's dog Wellington dead in her garden, stabbed with a garden fork, he decides to slip into the role of a detective and investigate the cruel crime. Whereas initially, he is convinced that Mr. Shears has committed the deed, later the course of the story takes an unexpected twist: not only does Christopher identify his father as the murderer but he also finds out that his mother is – contrary to his father's claims – still alive. The tension of the story lies in the way the autistic teenager perceives the world as opposed to other characters and in the difficulties resulting from this alternate perception and behaviour. Due to these differences, in some respects, Christopher Boone can be declared an unreliable narrator, above all along the axis of perception.

11.1 General characterisation of the 'unreliable' protagonist

Like most unreliable narrators, Christopher Boone relates his murder mystery in the first person and he is not only the narrator, but also the protagonist of the story. His presence

is explicitly perceivable: he is an *overt* narrator, who interprets and comments on the story in a highly subjective way. He talks a lot about himself and there are discrepancies and dramatic irony on two levels between what the narrator tries to convey and a second version of what happens, of which the narrator is unaware: the discrepancy on the first level lies in the difference between the narrator's and the recipient's grasp of the events that form the main narrative strands and thus bigger picture of the story. Whereas the recipient is aware that Christopher's father has lied to his son about his mother's death in order to protect him from the hurtful truth that his mother has left him, the narrator is convinced that his father is dangerous. This is illustrated by the discrepancy between his explicit utterances and the implicit characterisation of his father. The second level deals with discrepancies related to details. At some point in the story, for instance, Christopher points out: "I don't like it when Rhodri [one of his father's friends] laughs at me. Rhodri laughs at me a lot." (Haddon. *CID*: 84) As in the example just mentioned, the recipient's level of knowledge is higher than the narrator's. Whereas the reader shares his father's perspective, namely that Rhodri's behaviour just means that he "is being friendly" (84), Christopher is irritated by it. So even if Christopher's story is transmitted in a subjective way, he often integrates other voices such as his father's or his teacher Siobhan's.

Unlike typical unreliable narrators, however, Christopher refrains from addressing the reader or from justifying his behaviour: according to the author Mark Haddon (Weich 2003) "[h]e never tries to persuade the reader to feel about things this way or that way; he just kind of paints this picture and says, 'Make of it what you will.'"

11.2 Christopher Boone's mind and perception of the world

As already alluded to above, one of the aspects Mark Haddon shows himself most interested in consists in "how the human mind works" (Crompton 2006). This can also be observed in *Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*; there is an increased focus on Christopher's psychological disposition and mind. Tony Attwood (2008: 17), an expert on Asperger's Syndrome, stresses that a number of children with the impairment show signs of constant anxiety, a feeling also Haddon's narrator Christopher experiences

frequently. In his narration, Christopher tells the recipient about many situations that cause him stress, anxiety or a sensation of panic. Christopher is, for example, very sensitive to noise, which his behaviour at the train station illustrates: “And when I saw how big the room was that the train was in and I heard how noisy and echoey it was I had to kneel down on the ground for a bit because I thought I was going to fall over.” (207) According to Attwood (2008: 15), children with Asperger’s Syndrome sometimes perceive sounds as disagreeable that would not be so for a child without the disorder.

A sensation of panic is also reflected in the following incident. As soon as his mother tells him that this year he will not be able to sit his maths A-level, Christopher reveals how deeply this affects him: “And I started feeling a pain in my chest like I did on the underground because I thought I wasn’t going to be able to go back to Swindon and take my A-level.” (250) Christopher describes how he is troubled by his mother’s decision to postpone his taking his A-levels. She obviously underestimates the importance of the exam for her son. Christopher compares his feelings to the way he has felt on the tube on his way to London, where he sets off for after he has decided to live with his mother: “[t]he train wobbled a lot and I had to hang onto a rail and we went into a tunnel and it was noisy and I closed my eyes and I could feel the blood pumping in the sides of my neck.” (227)

This example also illustrates how *novel* situations cause him distress. Tony Attwood (2008: 56) states that children with this special impairment often react sensitively to alterations and that they may show signs of extreme anxiety when they notice a change in routine (Attwood 2008: 15). Christopher has never gone anywhere on his own, let alone by train, which is why he is so scared. Similarly, he is distressed by changes e.g. in the position of furniture in their house. When he lists his “Behavioural Problems” (59), he mentions as a last point “Getting cross when someone has moved the furniture” (60) and adds:

> It is permitted to move the chairs and the table in the kitchen because that is different but it makes me feel dizzy and sick if someone has moved the sofa and the chairs around in the living room or the dining room. Mother used to do this when she did the hoovering,

> so I made a special plan of where all the furniture was meant to be and did measurements and I put everything back in its proper place afterwards and then I felt better. But since Mother died Father hasn't done any hoovering so that is OK. And Mrs Shears did the hoovering once but I did groaning and she shouted at Father and she never did it again. (60)

Due to his dislike of new situations, he also hates holidays in France, which he refers to frequently. Going to France becomes a *leitmotif* that stands for novel situations and for the distress they cause in his mind. What he likes is when things are as always, timetables - like Sebastian Faulks's narrator Mike Engleby, he likes to know the time - and routines. Christopher also explains why he is troubled by new situations. One reason he mentions is that "[he] see[s] everything" (174). As opposed to situations and places he already knows, in which he can just concentrate on aspects that are different (174), he has to focus on so much in new situations that his mind becomes exhausted and is not able to function any more as it should. Once he grows accustomed to a situation, his anxiety decreases. In the underground, for instance, he does not board the train until the situation of trains' leaving and trains' arriving becomes a little bit more familiar to him. Another reason why Christopher dislikes new situations and feels uncomfortable on the underground is because they involve strangers and he is scared of them because they can behave unexpectedly. This is, again, a reason why he experiences a disturbed relationship to the outer world.

11.3 Christopher's social understanding and communicational abilities

As long as Christopher is alone, everything is fine. As soon as the narrator deals with others, though, his behaviour and communicational abilities can be perceived as problematic, as it happens often with people with Asperger's Syndrome, who can be "very unusual in terms of [their] ability to understand social situations and conventions" and who tend to "use their intellect rather than intuition to succeed in some social situations" (Attwood 2008: 15ff.). They may react in a phobic way in certain social contexts (cf. Attwood 2008: 18), as Christopher does, too. His reactions to such situations - such as imitating the barking of dogs - may be perceived as curious.

11.3.1 Non-verbal signals

There are various reasons for his behaviour in certain situations: the first reason is that Christopher has troubles understanding other people's emotions, as he explicitly states in one incident: "Usually people look at you when they're talking to you. I know that they're working out what I'm thinking, but I can't tell what they're thinking." (29) One reason for this lack of understanding is that he has difficulties interpreting people's faces due to their fast movements. When the protagonist's father asks him to stop investigating the murder of Wellington, Christopher perceives his father's anger not because of understanding his facial expression, but because of his raising his voice: "I could tell that he [Christopher's father] is angry because he was shouting" (27). According to Attwood (2008: 15), the lack of understanding non-verbal signs is typical for children with Asperger's Syndrome. Empathy and a feeling for people's thoughts, however, are crucial elements in interactions.

11.3.2 Verbal signals

However, also verbal signals can be difficult to understand, especially as far as the semantics of these verbal signals is concerned, as children with Asperger's Syndrome tend to interpret people's utterances literally (Attwood 2008: 16). Christopher does this frequently. He explains how he does not understand metaphors such as "He was the apple of her eye" (19) because "when [he] tr[ies] and make[s] a picture of the phrase in [his] head it just confuses [him] because imagining an apple in someone's eye doesn't have anything to do with liking someone a lot and it makes you forget what the person was talking about." (20) Also when, after he has arrived in London at his mum's flat completely drenched and she tells him to go inside because otherwise he will "catch [his] death" (235), the teenager fails to understand the meaning of the phrase.

Similarly, Christopher lacks the ability to understand jokes and irony or sarcasm as well. When, for instance, after his arrival in London, he asks a shop assistant to confirm that a specific book is what he is looking for, he does not understand that the shop assistant's

answer is meant to be sarcastic: “And I said, ‘Is that the A to Z?’ and I pointed at the book. And he said, ‘No, it’s a sodding crocodile.’ And I said, ‘Is that the A to Z?’ because it wasn’t a crocodile and I thought I had heard wrongly because of his accent.” (229) This citation shows that Christopher only understands literal utterances and that speech acts functioning in the figurative sense are confusing for him and can thus make communication problematic. This is why he likes being told precisely how he is supposed to behave:

> [W]hen people tell you what to do it is usually confusing and does not make sense. For example, people often say “Be quiet,” but they don’t tell you how long to be quiet for. […] Siobhan understands. When she tells me not to do something she tells me exactly what it is that I am not allowed to do. And I like this. For example, she once said, “You must never punch Sarah or hit her in any way, Christopher. Even if she hits you first. If she does hit you again, move away from her and stand still and count from 1 to 50, then come and tell me what she has done, or tell one of the other members of staff what she has done.” (38f.)

In addition, Christopher explains that he does not understand chatting. A conversation with Mrs. Alexander, who lives in the same street as Christopher, namely Randolph Street, demonstrates how he reacts in social situations in which people try to converse casually with him: “I didn’t reply to this either because Mrs Alexander was doing what is called chatting where people say things to each other which aren’t questions and answers and aren’t connected.” (51) Even if in this particular case, namely a conversation with an adult, his reaction does not really create tension, one can imagine how kids or teenagers or, to be more specific, his peers, may be less tolerant towards his awkward behaviour such as not replying when they interact with each other.

11.3.3 Christopher’s attitude towards his peers

As far as his classmates or schoolmates are concerned, he has a low opinion of them and does not appear to be interested in interacting with them. He declares them stupid in several occasions. In Chapter 71, for example, in which he addresses his ambition to take his A-levels and to go to university, he makes it clear: “All the other children at my school [- a school for children with Special Needs -] are stupid.” (56) Whereas in that

citation, Christopher talks about his schoolmates in general, in other occasions he refers to the stupidity of specific people, such as Terry, one of his schoolmates' brother. Their relationship, though, seems to be mutually deprecating: "Terry […] said I would only ever get a job collecting supermarket trollies or cleaning out donkey shit at an animal sanctuary and they didn't let spazzers drive rockets that cost millions of pounds." Terry has obviously made this statement in response to Christopher's dream to be an astronaut.

However, not only verbal violence but also physical violence characterises Christopher's interaction with his peers: "I can hit people very hard. For example, when I punched Sarah because she had pulled my hair I knocked her unconscious and she had a concussion and they had to take her to the Accident and Emergency Department at the hospital." (45) Christopher's behaviour towards Sarah and other peers also can result from the fact that he has Asperger's Syndrome, as these children sometimes show a "depressive reaction [that] can [result] in criticism of others and expression of frustration or anger, especially when the child has difficulty understanding a social situation" (Attwood 2008: 18). Christopher, though, does not appear to worry a great deal about his social isolation.

11.3.4 Social isolation

Due to this lack of understanding emotions, language and social conventions, children with Asperger's Syndrome may react with social withdrawal. Their attitude towards their peers' social activities is neutral and they do not want them to engage in what they do either. A failure to socially integrate can be considerably depressing (cf. Attwood 2008: 17ff.) and, as a consequence, children with Asperger's Syndrome may "escape into imagination" and "develop vivid and complex imaginary worlds, sometimes with make-believe friends [who] can prevent [them] from feeling lonely." (Attwood 2008: 24). Christopher Boone does not appear to be interested in interaction with his peers or classmates, either. He compensates his lack of social interaction by his intense interest in space, which represents a far away world. Attwood (2008: 25) states that "[s]earching for an alternative world can lead some children [with Asperger's Syndrome] to develop an

interest in another culture, period of history or the world of animals […]. The interest in other cultures and worlds can explain the development of a special interest in geography, astronomy and science fiction, such that the child discovers a place where his or her knowledge and abilities are recognized and valued." Sometimes, Christopher imagines a world without people, except people like him, i.e. people who have Asperger's Syndrome as well, who would enjoy being alone as he does:

> And when I was asleep I had one of my favourite dreams. Sometimes I have it during the day, but then it's a daydream. But I often have it at night as well. And in the dream nearly everyone on the earth is dead, because they have caught a virus. […] And I can go anywhere in the world and I know that no one is going to talk to me or touch me or ask me a question. (242f.)

Apart from that, he frequently talks about his pet rat Toby, who is like a friend to him. He also mentions his fondness for dogs several times, because, in contrast to people, "[y]ou always know what a dog is thinking." (4)

11.3.5 The semantics of space

What above was referred to as the semantics of space, which often supports the narrator's isolated state, can also be observed in *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*: Christopher's inner disability to communicate is frequently reflected in the outer isolation of the character. His dislike for crowded places such as the train station supports this isolation. On the train from Swindon to London, for example, he hides in a shelf:

> Then I went out of the toilet and I saw that opposite the toilet there were two shelves with cases and a rucksack on them and it made me think of the airing cupboard at home and how I climb in there sometimes and it makes me feel safe. So I climbed onto the middle shelf and I pulled one of the cases across like a door so that I was shut in, and it was dark and there was no one in there with me and I couldn't hear people talking so I felt much calmer and it was nice. (Haddon. *CID*: 201)

Christopher's curious behaviour causes amazement and disapproval in his fellow passengers: "[O]ne person saw me and they said 'You are fucking weird, mate' and that was a man in a suit." (206) The cabinet he recalls when spotting the shelf on the train has

already been referred to above, when Christopher reveals his appreciation for small rooms: “I like really little spaces, so long as there is no one else in them with me. Sometimes when I want to be on my own I get into the airing cupboard in the bathroom and slide in beside the boiler and pull the door closed behind me and sit there and think for hours and it makes me feel very calm.” (65) Christopher Boone’s hiding place on the train and especially the cupboard may remind the recipient of Patrick McGrath’s narrator Dennis Cleg, who at some point starts to appreciate the safety and peacefulness of a cupboard, too:

> I spent half an hour sitting cross-legged gazing into the cupboard, the lighter burning fitfully on the floor in front of me. Then I took everything out, set it all neatly on the kitchen floor, and climbed in myself – not an easy task, I am not small! But with my head on my chest, and the U-shaped pipe in my lap, and my arms round my knees, I was able to squeeze in and pull the door shut. For ten minutes I sat there squashed up in the darkness, and felt great peace. Then I climbed out and turned the taps on; with the sound of running water in the pipe the little cupboard was heavenly, and now I am spending thirty or forty minutes in there every night. (McGrath. *S*: 213)

Also an incident in which Christopher finds himself in a car with his mother and several schoolmates and he simply gets off the vehicle and another case his mother refers to in one of her letters, where Christopher has laid down on the ground in the shop in which they have intended to buy a Christmas gift for his grandmother, support his fondness for being on his own and show how panicky he can become when he is in the company of other people, especially in small and closed or very crowded places.

11.3. 6 Christopher’s attitude towards strangers

To a certain extent, the narrator dislikes such places because he feels uncomfortable when he is surrounded by strangers. He is afraid of being talked to or of being touched by them, which is why his talking to people in order to investigate Wellington’s murder is only an exception: “Talking to strangers is not something I usually do. I do not like talking to strangers. This is not because of **Stranger Danger** which they tell us about at school, which is where a strange man offers you sweets or a ride in his car because he wants to do sex with you. I am not worried about that. If a strange man touched me I would hit

him" (45). This is exactly what happens to the policeman who appears at the scene of the crime at the beginning of the novel: "The policeman took hold of my arm and lifted me onto my feet. I didn't like him touching me like this. And this is when I hit him." (8f.)

Even if Christopher hates crowded places and being with strangers, he still recognizes that he needs somebody to take care of him and he even talks about a possible future wife so that he will not be alone. This indicates his longing for appreciation, an aspect typical for many unreliable narrators who find themselves in states of isolation:

> Then, when I've got a degree in Maths, or Physics, or Maths and Physics, I will be able to get a job and earn lots of money and I will be able to pay someone who can look after me and cook my meals and wash my clothes, or I will get a lady to marry me and be my wife and she can look after me so I can have company and not be on my own. (58)

11.3.7 Communication

As far as communication is concerned, Christopher values the truth and is often very direct towards other people. In Chapter 73, in a footnote, he explains how he feels about this: "People say that you always have to tell the truth. But they do not mean this because you are not allowed to tell old people that they are old and you are not allowed to tell people if they smell funny of if a grown-up has made a fart. And you are not allowed to say, 'I don't like you,' unless that person has been horrible to you." (60) In one incident, for example, when he looks lost at the train station and a woman offers to help him, he immediately makes it clear: "'Stand further away'" (226) because he feels threatened by her closeness. It goes without saying that statements like this that are too direct and truthful can lead to social unease.

However, sometimes Christopher does not communicate at all ("Once I didn't talk to anyone for 5 weeks." [59]). For example, he needs a lot of time to become familiar with new teachers or psychologists at school and refuses to speak to them until several weeks have passed:

> It takes me a long time to get used to people I do not know. For example, when there is a new member of staff at school I do not talk to them for weeks and weeks. I just watch them until I know that they are safe. Then I ask them questions about themselves, like whether they have pets and what is their favourite colour and what do they know about the Apollo space missions and I get them to draw a plan of their house and I ask them what kind of car they drive, so I get to know them. Then I don't mind if I am in the same room as them and don't have to watch them all the time. (46)

Apart from that, Christopher does not talk on certain days he calls "**Black Day[s]**", which is when the school bus passes four yellow cars one after another. This obviously has to do with his dislike for the colour yellow. "**Black Day[s]**" are days "when [he doesn't] speak to anyone and sit[s] on [his] own reading books and [doesn't] eat [his] lunch and *Take*[s] *No Risks*." (31)

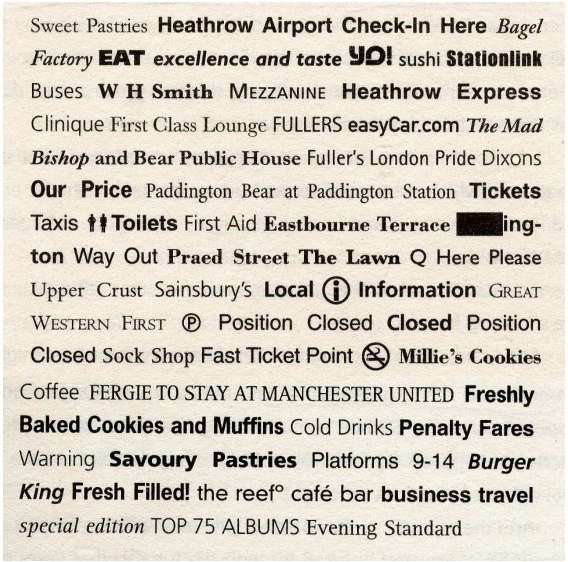
Concerning social conventions, however, one can notice that Christopher has an ambition to learn and that he is striving to respond adequately in situations in which he is surrounded by people. When his father's friend Rhodri, for instance, asks him how he is he responds according to what he has been taught to be socially adequate: "And I said, 'I'm doing very well, thank you,' which is what you're meant to say." (83)

11.4 The unreliability of memory

When it comes to the analysis of *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night*-Time, the various passages in the novel in which the narrator talks about how well his memory works are also of interest. Unlike other unreliable narrators, who often treat other characters like objects, Christopher considers himself or, to be more precise, his memory, object-like. He compares it to a film that can be rewound and forwarded as he wishes from being approximately four years onwards:

> My memory is like a film. That is why I am really good at remembering things, like the conversations I have written down in this book, and what people were wearing, and what they smelled like, because my memory has a smelltrack which is like a soundtrack.
>
> And when people ask me to remember something I can simply press **Rewind** and **Fast Forward** and **Pause** like on a video recorder, but more like a DVD because I don't have to Rewind through everything in between to get to a memory of something a long time ago. And there are no buttons, either, because it is happening in my head. (96)

Christopher adds some examples to his statement, in which he explains how he can simply go back to a certain date of time and describe where he has been with his mother, the clothes she has worn and what exactly they have been doing and saying. This method of going back and forward is also what he applies when people make an utterance he does not understand in order to figure out whether he has already heard it in a previous occasion or not. The increased ability to recall events might create the initial impression that Christopher is an extremely reliable narrator, even if one has to be aware of the fact that especially unreliable narrators tend to assure the reader that their statements are accurate. This is not the case here, though, as Christopher does not strive to convince the reader and as he really has a good memory. On looking closer, the recipient, however, is still forced to admit that the character is not that reliable as initially assumed, not only because of his distorted perception, but also because of the kind of blackouts he has on several occasions, which is when his brain fails to work correctly. What originally looks like image 2a in his head, then turns into 2b:



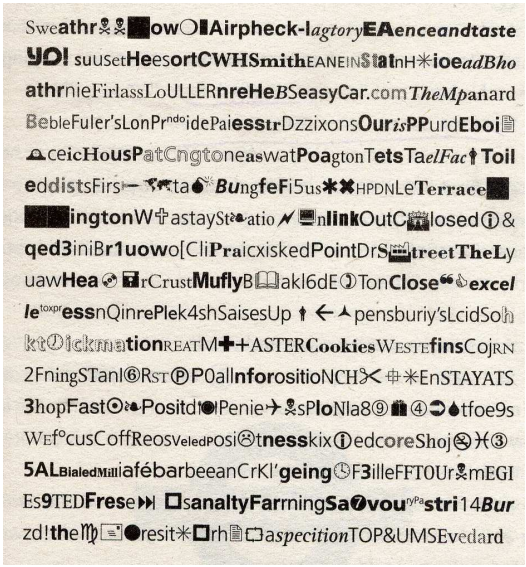


Fig. 2a Fig. 2b (208f.)

In one case, for instance, when he is so stressed after arriving at the train station, he seems to have been so engaged in solving a maths example in his head in order to clear his brain, that he fails to notice what is happening around him. Therefore, the recipient

might become suspicious of the correctness of Christopher's report of events. Obviously he stays in that absent-minded state until a policeman addresses him. The officer's statement demonstrates how the narrator is perceived by his environment when he finds himself in a state like that: "[H]e [the policeman] said, 'The lady at the café says you've been here for 2 ½ hours and when she tried talking to you, you were in a complete trance.'" (184)

Here a parallel to Sebastian Faulks's narrator Mike Engleby can be found. Mike also stresses the good functionality of his memory: "I have a world in my mind, in the inexhaustible repertoire of my memory. I can recall at will, note-perfect, from the reams I have stored there." (Faulks. *E*: 336) Sometimes, though, Engleby appears not to be aware of his surroundings any more and consequently, his memory fails to remember anything that has happened during that period of time. So, like Christopher Boone's memory, Mike's memory is fallible, e.g. when it comes to the recollection of what happened during a panic attack.

Another incidence in which Christopher's memory turns out to be confused is when, after a sleepless night, it turns out that, contrary to his expectations, he can still take his A-levels and he is not able to recall what he has studied, even if usually his memory usually functions like a machine: "I wanted to do my Maths A level but I was very tired and when I tried to think about Maths my brain didn't work properly and when I tried to remember certain facts, like the logarithmic formula for the approximate number of prime numbers not greater than **(x)**, I couldn't remember them and this made me frightened." (257)

11.5 Language and style

As far as the language Christopher uses is concerned, despite of the numerous scientific explanations he gives, his style is simple and infantile. The recipient is confronted with the story through the eyes of a naïve teenager, which makes them critical towards certain

perceptions he conveys and suspect that not everything he says can be considered reliable.

As already insinuated in the theoretical part of this paper, his style is often factual when the reader would expect him to be more emotional in his reactions. When Mrs. Alexander tells him about the relationship between his mother and Mr. Shears, he responds in an unexpectedly neutral way. He tells his neighbour that he has to leave without any indications that what she has just told him afflicts him in any way, supposedly because of his failure to grasp its implications. Also when Siobhan addresses the topic he negates that it troubles him: "And she [Siobhan] said, 'Did it make you sad to find this out?' And I asked, 'Find what out?' And she said, 'Did it make you upset to find out that your mother and Mr Shears had an affair?' And I said, 'No.' And she said, 'Are you telling the truth, Christopher?' And then I said, 'I always tell the truth.'" (95) Despite Siobhan's subsequent assurance that it would be alright if he felt miserable, he keeps denying such a sensation. By way of explanation, he adds that it would be senseless to feel sadness because his mum has died anyway and thus his feeling would be unreal.

By contrast, the language he uses in situations when he is stressed is more emotional: "And I felt like I felt like when I had flu and I had to stay in bed all day and all of me hurt and I couldn't walk or eat or go to sleep or do maths." (216) The repetition of the phrase "I felt like" at the beginning of the sentence indicates the character's high emotional involvement. However, typical signals for an unreliable narrator's emotionally highly involved speech such as repetitions, fragmented utterances or exclamatory sentences are rather rare.

11.6 Meta textual pre-information and paratextual signals

As far as meta textual pre-information is concerned, it is worth pointing out that in the Vintage 2004 edition of Mark Haddon's work, the blurb refers to the fact that *CID* is a story told by a narrator with Asperger's Syndrome. Thus the reader already receives a hint indicating that it is narrated in a special way that may be unreliable to a certain

extent before they even start reading. Once the reader has opened the book, they may notice another aspect pointing towards unreliable narration. Contrary to their knowledge of literary conventions, according to which chapters are usually numbered – if they are numbered at all – starting with 1, it is striking that this novel's first chapter heading is number '2'. The narrator numbers the chapters of his narrative according to prime numbers, which demonstrates his avocation for logic and maths. The Appendix, in which he shows how he has solved the tasks in his maths A-levels exam, underlines this passion. The unusual way of numbering the chapters alone would not be enough to call a narrator unreliable. However, it differs from the common numbering of chapters in literary works and, additionally, it is related to the increased fascination for a specific subject area that is a key characteristic in the diagnosis of Asperger's Syndrome (cf. Attwood 2008: 12). The impairment is closely linked to the narrator's curious way of perceiving the world and thus the narrator's unreliability.

11.6 Discrepancies, paradoxes and secret messages

Christopher's curious transmission as well as perception of the world and his at times socially inadequate behaviour lead to an advancing exposure of his mind, which goes hand in hand with the recipient's establishment of *frames of reference.* Often the narrator's utterances, however, fail to fit into already established *frames*, which stresses his unreliability. These utterances arise parallel to Christopher's dealing with various characters. As far as Mrs Alexander is concerned, Christopher implicitly describes her in a way so that the recipient has the impression that she is an utterly amiable character. She seems highly pleased when Christopher addresses her in her garden for the first time and offers him tea and cake. Whereas the recipient has no doubts about the lady's good intentions, Christopher becomes suspicious and paranoid that she may call the police and so he leaves, while she is in the house fetching the cake. The reader is critical towards Christopher's explicit speculations about the goodness of her character because these speculations do not agree with the *frame* they have established about Mrs. Alexander's just being a friendly neighbour. The implicit descriptions Christopher provides about her assume a status of privilege over his explicit doubts.

Likewise, the recipient has a higher level of information as far as Christopher's intention to reside with his mother is concerned. The narrator's naïveté leads him to the assumption that he can simply go to London and live with her because he fails to take the aspects that have made her leave their house in Swindon into account. The recipient is aware that it might not be as simple as Christopher imagines.

Those, however, are not the only discrepancies the recipient is confronted with in *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*. One of the most basic paradoxes is that Christopher is highly ill-suited for writing a novel due to his lack of understanding metaphors and emotions (cf. Weich 2003). Apart from that, he states that he has difficulties imagining events ("I find hard to imagine things which did not happen to me." [5]) and imagination can be considered as an essential ability one has to have when it comes to writing a novel. Moreover, he explains that the novel is not humorous as he fails to understand the meaning of jokes but at the same time, the book creates many comic situations (cf. Holcombe 2004). One of these situations occurs, when Mrs. Alexander talks to Christopher about the reason why his father dislikes Mr. Shears and the narrator's first assumption is that it can be ascribed to Mr. Shear's being the murderer of his mother.

Partly the novel is so funny due to Christopher's straightforward behaviour (cf. Holcombe 2004) and his fondness of the truth, which is why "everything [he has] written here [in the murder mystery] is true." (25) People with Asperger's Syndrome, namely, are extremely honest. They say what they think because they are unable to tell lies (Berger 2010: 15). At the same time, however, the narrator "gets everything wrong" (Weich 2003).

As far as *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* is concerned, it is relatively easy for the recipient to figure out what really happens in the story as they have a higher level of knowledge than Christopher, who looks at things in his own innocent and naïve way.

In the following books this paper will analyse, however, it is a more challenging task for the reader to create a second version of the story.

12. *Spider* by Patrick McGrath

Patrick McGrath, the author of *Spider,* the second novel that will be analysed in this paper, spent his childhood near Broadmoor Hospital, located in close proximity to London. His father worked at the hospital for many years, which is "Britain's largest top-security institution for mentally ill offenders" (Falco 2007: 14). Consequently, the topics of madness and mental dysfunction, combined with unreliable narration, permeate his literary works. The grotesque, fragmentation, the Gothic and intertextuality play an important role, too. At the age of about 20, Patrick McGrath left Britain for Canada. There he worked in an institution for the mentally ill. In New York, which is where he moved to next, he published his first story collection in 1988 as well as his first novel, *The Grotesque*, in 1989.

One year later, the publication of his second novel, *Spider*, followed (cf. Falco 2007: 14). *Spider* centres on the schizophrenic narrator Dennis Cleg - or Spider, as his mother used to call him - who tells his story beginning with his growing up in London to how he comes to end up in a psychiatric institution. Tormented by past occurrences, he desperately tries to make sense of the events that happened by writing them down in a journal. These events focus, above all, on his father Horace and Dennis's obsession that his dad has killed his mother. By telling Horace's story, however, he reveals even more about himself. He allows the reader to follow his thoughts and grants them access to his deep psyche that suffers from delusions and hallucinations. Because of these, the recipient develops a sceptical attitude and is forced to create their own alternative version of the story instead of blindly accepting Dennis's representation of facts and his way of interpreting the world.

12.1 General characterisation of the ‘unreliable’ protagonist

Like Christopher Boone, Dennis is a homodiegetic first-person narrator, who is also the main character of the story. His narration is *overt* in that the recipient can very clearly feel his presence as he constantly comments on the events taking place. Dennis can be considered both a static and a dynamic character. He is static inasmuch as the *narrating I* shows little distance to the *experiencing I:* the restlessness of his mind he has experienced as a child is still the same when he thinks back as an adult. His father’s encounter with Hilda Wilkinson – does she really exist? - marks a turning point in the story, from which the stability of his psyche is decreasing rapidly, however. So in this respect, Dennis can be considered a dynamic character, as his psyche lives through a development heading towards a complete mental breakdown and self-destruction, topics which can often be found in unreliable narratives. The frequent address of the reader, which is so typical for unreliable narration as well, constitutes a central element. He tries to convince the *implied reader* of his version of the story but due to his fragile mental condition and due to various clues the recipient is implicitly given through the integration of other characters’ perspectives, his ambitions fail. So he can definitely be declared an unreliable narrator, which the narratologist Ansgar Nünning (1997: 100) supports, as the following quote shows:

> [N]arrators who violate the standards that a given culture holds to be constitutive of normal psychological behaviour are generally taken to be unreliable. What is involved here is psychological theories of personality or implicit models of normal human behaviour. It does not take the reader very long, for example, to figure out that the narrator[…] in Patrick McGrath’s novel[…] *Spider* [is] […] unreliable and mad as hatters simply because [he] strikingly depart[s] from conventional notions of psychic normality.

12.2 Psychological condition

As in *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*, one can notice a focus on the psychological condition of the narrator in *Spider* as well. Even if in the general characterisation of the character above the change of Dennis’s mental state is pointed out, it is still clear from the beginning that his mind differs from accepted common

conceptions of ‘normality’. This is because already on the first page he mentions “people in the attic” (McGrath. *Spider:* 9). In spite of the fact that initially, the meaning of the phrase might still be blurred, its reference to acoustic hallucinations - the voices he hears in his head - which are widely spread among people with schizophrenia (cf. Alanen 2001: 41), soon becomes clear. No sooner has he addressed this peculiarity than he draws the reader’s attention to another deficit: he easily loses control over his physical movements. This is illustrated by his description of the processes that are involved when he engages in everyday activities such as walking, getting dressed or consuming food:

> It takes me about ten minutes to walk from the canal back to Mrs. Wilkinson’s. I am not a fast walker; I shuffle, rather than walk, and often I am forced to stop dead in the middle of the pavement. I forget how to do it, you see, for nothing is automatic with me anymore, not since I came back from Canada. The simplest actions – eating, dressing, going to the lavatory – can sometimes pose near-insurmountable problems, not because I am physically handicapped in any way, but rather because I lose the easy, fluid sense of being-in-the-body that I once had; the linkage of brain and limb is a delicate mechanism, and often, now, for me, it becomes uncoupled. (9f.)

The abnormalities of Dennis’s behaviour and the constant unease of his mind result, above all, from situations when he feels stressed and to which he reacts in a phobic way. In this respect, Dennis Cleg is similar to Christopher Boone, who also has difficulty to keep his mind functioning properly in situations that place the character into states of agitation.

As far as Dennis is concerned, the anxiety he suffers from appears to occur, above all, in connexion with memories involving his father and Kitchener Street, situated in London’s East End. This is where the Clegs lived when the narrator was a child: “The more involved I am in memories of my father the more frequently it [the uncoupling of the linkage of brain and limb] seems to happen” (10). When he mentions his childhood home for the first time, he also gives a vague indication that a tragic incidence happened way back. Like the narratives of typical *mad monologists*, Dennis’s narration centres obsessively on his reminiscences without revealing essential information until later. This allows a focus on the narrator’s psyche rather than on events and maintains the reader’s interest. He appears to withhold valuable information from the recipient consciously to a

certain extent, as the following utterance addressed to the *implied reader* reveals: "[W]hen you learn the full story you will understand my trepidation." (127) Dennis feels compelled to return to the place where he grew up. His mind, however, becomes deeply afflicted when he tries to do so: "I haven't yet been back to Kitchener Street; I feel apprehensive about crossing the canal and seeing again those blackened bricks, imbued as they are in my memory with the sounds and smells of the tragedy that occurred there. One day I must do it, I know, but not yet, not yet." (17) Obviously, although he ponders the idea of revisiting the place every day, he is unable to bring himself to go there. When he approaches, he finds himself at the verge of a panic attack so that he is forced to return:

> [B]arely had I decided to go further, and see what had become of my father's garden […] than a goods train went wildly shrieking beneath me, and in a sort of shambling panic I scampered back the way I'd come and was a few moments later clinging limply to a lamppost with my heart leaping and racing in my chest and my ears ringing with the sound of the train, a terrible sound that for a few seconds turned into a howl of mockery from some tribe of invisible imps, so it seemed! (18)

This unusual emotional reaction to everyday occurrences like a passing train results from his disconcerted mind when he attempts to confront his past. The hallucination involving mythological creatures ridiculing him function as an indication for the instability of his mental state.

12.3 Dennis's journal

Because of the smooth line between the emotions of his present 'I' and his past self and with the aim of achieving some order in his life, the narrator confides his thoughts to a journal, a kind of diary. Thus he tries to gain distance from the memories that haunt him:

> I grew up in this part of London, in the East End, and while in one sense the changes are total, and I am a stranger, in another sense nothing has changed: there are ghosts, and there are memories, and they rise in clusters as I catch a glimpse of the underside of a familiar railway bridge, a familiar view of the river at dusk, the gasworks – they haven't changed at all – and my memories have a way of crowding in upon the scene and collapsing the block of time that separates then from now, producing […] a sort of running together of past and present such that I am confused, and I forget, so rich and

> immediate are the memories, that I am what I am, a shuffling, spidery figure in a worn-out suit, and not a dreamy boy of twelve or so. It is for this reason that I have decided to keep a journal. (10)

In an interview with Magali Falco (2007: 23), the author explains that Dennis is "trying to make a deal with reality, trying to fix it." However, "the attempts to fix it don't work […] [He] can't fix reality so [he] drift[s] into wilder and wilder territory …". This coincides with what Dennis refers to at some point in the story: "[I]t was ironic, I thought, down on my hands and knees at the fireplace, keeping a journal was supposed to help me sort out the muddle I made between memory and sensation, and here it was simply increasing the confusion." (92)

Unlike Christopher Boone, who is aware of the fact that his murder mystery novel, a narrative within a narrative, will have an audience (e.g. his teacher Siobhan), Dennis writes in his journal for private reasons and nobody is supposed to read it, especially not Mrs. Wilkinson, a woman who looks after Dennis and five other residents in an assisted living facility. He is paranoid and constantly uneasy about her discovering his hiding place so that in the end, after placing it in the fireplace so many times, it is so covered with soot that it can barely be recognised as a journal anymore: "It is very late at night as I write this, and I don't know if you can understand the anxiety I feel at committing these thoughts to paper. If she [Mrs. Wilkinson] should find this book the consequences would be appalling, and I don't like to think about that" (127).

His mentioning that he cannot even bare considering the possibility of Mrs. Wilkinson's discovery of the journal demonstrates how deeply his mind would be troubled by a possible penalty such as confiscation. This is why he attempts to conceal it properly:

> I am fairly satisfied with the fireplace as the site of concealment, although it does have the drawback of being very sooty in there – after only a few days the book became so filthy I had to put it in a brown paper bag before stuffing it away, using my mittens so as to keep my hands clean. This system worked well until yesterday morning, when I realized that if she found the sooty mittens her suspicions would be aroused and she'd go poking around in the fireplace to see what I was up to – which left me the problem (I'm fastidious to the point of absurdity, you'll say, but believe me, I cannot afford to take the

> chance) the problem of finding a safe place of concealment for the mittens (under the linoleum perhaps?) or, alternatively, of getting rid of them. (127)

He continues by explaining how he has decided to opt for the second possibility and how he has then disposed of the gloves. Moreover, the narrator alludes to the implications this decision has brought about. He gives so much thought to issues related to his journal that the recipient might perceive his behaviour as awkward. At any rate, Dennis is aware that the *implied reader* might be struck with the absurdity of his manners, as it can be deduced from the reader address above ("I'm fastidious to the point of absurdity, you'll say, but believe me, I cannot afford to take the chance"). Because of the narrator's anticipation in the form of an assumption, however, he justifies his behaviour even before the *implied reader* has a chance to actually declare it bizarre. This suggests that Dennis is, to a certain extent, aware of the abnormality of his conduct.

The paranoia he develops related to the journal reveals, most of all, the importance it has for him. His descriptions suggest that his relationship to the book is similar to a bond between friends and can thus be interpreted as a compensation for his lack of social connexions. When weakness, mental unease and fear of destruction plague him - instead of relieving his mind by talking to a friend - his journal along with cigarettes represent safety and something to hold on to: "And as always it's the journal and the tobacco alone that provide what little scaffolding I have." (212)

12.4 Solitude

Dennis, namely, is a loner. The only person he can really relate to is his mother, maybe because they share the alienation to their surroundings. She is highly admired by her son. His mother gives him an understanding of how fascinating books are and they exchange their thoughts and fantasies. This is why after her death, Dennis experiences even more solitude: "After that, you see, I was quite, quite alone, and without her love, her influence, without, simply, her *presence* I quickly went adrift." (96)

He likes being invisible, which is why he enjoys being in the obscurity of the cellar and presumably this is also a reason for his fondness of fog. His room represents a safe place, which shows his appreciation for being alone. Also, occasionally he totters down the streets near his residence, which he describes as “empty”, “vacant” and “untenanted” (20) and he passes plenty of time by the canal, a “lonely place” (30) all by himself. “I tended to drift off by myself whenever I could, down to the canal, or down to the river, especially in damp and foggy weather.” (95) These places, conditions and the adjectives he uses to describe them mirror Dennis’s isolation, a common state among people who suffer from schizophrenia (cf. Alanen 2001: 45). Already as a child, he is an outsider, not keen on spending time with his peers and without any desire to make friends. His reference to the unhappiness he experienced at school, however, implies that he was not satisfied with this isolation: “As for school, I was never happy there, and I tried to avoid the place as much as I could. I had no friends, I didn’t want any friends, I didn’t like any of them, and over the years they’d learned to leave me alone. I shudder to think of those days, even now” (25). Again, the narrator establishes a connexion between the past and the present by indicating that he is still horrified when he reflects on these times. As he does not even get on with the other outsiders, he becomes more and more introverted until he drops out of school:

> [T]here was no sort of alliance possible between us, in fact we hated each other more bitterly than the other children hated us, because to each other we presented an image of our own pathetic isolation. I doubt I was missed when I stopped going to school; there would have been a neat line of *absents* in the register, and one less set of homework to mark. Nobody cared. (25f.)

The reference to his pitiable seclusion suggests that he has a desire for social appreciation despite his seemingly great fondness for being on his own. This statement can be supported by an occurrence during his stay at the psychiatric institution of Ganderhill, in which one of the staff members performs an appreciative gesture by touching Dennis: “And then he put a hand on my shoulder, and I walked back out onto the ward – odd thing, this – almost choking for the sheer joy of that hand on my shoulder.” (142). The way his joyful reaction takes him almost by surprise indicates that his longing for companionship is partly subconscious. Sometimes, however, he also

refers to it explicitly: “Perhaps the cruelest aspect of the situation was that my grief could be shared with no one.” (97) He continues with allusions to his misery, wishing that his mother was still alive. Part of his antisocial behaviour probably results from the fact that already his parents’ behaviour is marked by a lack of social relations.

Dennis appears to be almost exclusively engrossed in his own world so that in the end, he recognises that he is unable to chat with people anymore: “Then, to my horror, in the Dog [a bar] one afternoon, he attempted a conversation with Ernie Ratcliff. Oh dear God the humiliation! He had no aptitude for it, no ease, it had been years since he’d practised casual conversation with a stranger.” (215f.). In this quotation, when using ‘he’ the narrator refers to the part of his multiple personalities that represent his father. The formal aspect of the lack of (casual) dialogues underlines this inability to communicate. The narrator dislikes being with his fellow residents and rarely talks to them. When Mrs. Wilkinson addresses him after he complains to the other residents of the bad equipment of the place, he is highly troubled and withdrawn. He neither holds eye contact nor responds verbally in any way:

> Mrs. Wilkinson was standing there with her arms folded across her chest. I fell silent. […] “Mr. Cleg,” she said, advancing into the room. I turned sideways in my chair, averted my face to the wall and crossed my legs. I began to fumble with my tobacco. “Mr. Cleg,” she said, “I do sincerely wish that I could provide you with a billiard table and a library, but this is not a rich house, and so we must shift for ourselves – as you do, Mr. Cleg, I wish more of the residents would get out for a stroll.” (46)

During the ‘conversation’, Dennis does not utter a single word. He tries to ignore Mrs. Wilkinson by focusing on his tobacco and by trying to avoid meeting her eye. Inside, however, he is raging.

> Still sideways in my chair, my face still averted, I grew rigid. I burned with humiliation. From my trembling fingers shreds of tobacco spilled onto my trousers. Several moments passed. A weary sigh, then, from my tormentor. “Mr. Cleg, how many shirts are you wearing? What about our agreement?” Agreement! I was frozen stiff by this point. I abandoned the effort to roll a cigarette. My fingers hung poised and immobile, a paper between two fingers of the left hand, a pinch of tobacco in the right. Silence. What was she doing? Then, from one of the dead souls: “She’s gone, Mr. Cleg,” and I slowly relaxed, though my fingers kept twitching for at least another quarter of an hour. (46f.)

Dennis's strong emotional reaction seems to result from the fact that he reminds her of someone with the same name, an aspect he is not conscious about yet when he arrives at the assisted living residence where Mrs. Wilkinson works and to which he is sent to live after Ganderhill.

12.5 Hilda Wilkinson

When the narrator Dennis Cleg refers to Mrs. Wilkinson (who operates on the level of the present, where also the *narrating I* is situated) for the first time, he immediately draws a connexion to a character who belongs to the world of the narrator's *experiencing I*, namely Hilda Wilkinson. As Dennis moves along with his story of how his father meets his lover, his becoming acquainted with her (mainly on a sexual basis) and her complicity in the murder, Hilda's existence creates a lot of bewilderment and riddles in the recipient's mind.

Furthermore, she functions as a representative signal for the confusion in the narrator's psyche. In one incident, Dennis confides to his journal that during his childhood, he suffered from nightmares – which are typical for the Gothic genre - and then describes a specific one in detail: in an uncanny atmosphere down by the canal in the dead of the night, Dennis observes his father burying the dead body of his mother in his garden, a little patch of land with a shed within walking distance from the family's house in Kitchener Street. Apart from Horace's, Dennis can make out Hilda's presence as well. After waking up, he hurries into the kitchen, where he finds his father insisting that the lady next to him is his mother, and not, as Dennis assumes, a strange woman whose name he does not know at this point of time:

> I opened the door. My father was sitting at the table with a woman I had never seen before. "What is it?" he said. "What's the matter with you?" he rose to his feet and led me out of the kitchen into the passage, closing the door behind him. "Back upstairs," he said, guiding me down the passage, "back to bed, Dennis." "Where's my mum?" I said, trying to resist his forward propulsion. "Come on, son back to bed." "Where's my mum?" I cried. "I don't want to go back to bed, I had a dream!" "That's enough," he said, pushing me down the passage. "I want my mum!" "Don't make me angry, Dennis Your mum's in the kitchen." "No she's not!" (79)

Scared because of the vivid dream he has just had, his state of mind becomes even more discomposed when he believes the woman sitting next to his father a stranger, namely the stranger who he later holds responsible for his mother's death. Obviously, from then on, he fails to recognise his mother and confuses her with the strange woman Hilda Wilkinson. His father's reaction suggests that he has no idea what Dennis is talking about. He sends him back to sleep, after Dennis has enquired him once again about the stranger's identity. Even if the *narrating I* explicitly identifies his observation as a nightmare, the distinction between fantasy and reality becomes blurred. Due to the integration of his father's perspective or rather reaction, a kind of dramatic irony is created. Even if the reader cannot be completely sure about it at that point of the story, they suspect that the woman really is Dennis's mother and thus ascribe the narrator's reaction to madness. When Dennis describes Hilda wearing his mother's clothes and performing tasks in the kitchen in exactly the same way as his mother has done and indicates the blurred transition from his mother's to Hilda's carrying out the household chores, the reader's scepticism towards Dennis's distorted perspective grows even more: "How smoothly, you notice, Hilda had assumed my mother's role in the everyday domestic routines" (117). When the barman Ernie Ratcliff explains at the end of the book how Dennis's mother died, their suspicions are confirmed. Whereas the narrator is convinced that he has killed Hilda, in reality he took the life of his own mother. Even if Dennis is not aware of the real nature of happenings, however, deep in his subconscious he appears to be plagued with guilt. Without an explicit allusion to what he is responsible for, he refers to a voice telling him "this is your doing." (206) several times. Explicitly, though, he just pretends to be repentant for practical purposes, namely in order to achieve a privileged position at the psychiatric institution Ganderhill.

> "Why did you do it, son? Any idea?"
> "I didn't mean to, sir. It was a mistake."
> "Sorry you did it, then?"
> "Yes sir."
> "Well that's a start. Eh, Mr. Thomas? That's a start, eh?"
> "Yes sir," said Mr. Thomas from the door.
> "Don't suppose you'll ever do it again," said Dr. Austin Marshall. "Only got one mother after all." He looked up with raised eyebrows; I had been told on no account to mention

> what my father had done. Mr. Thomas cleared his voice, a reminder. I stayed silent. The superintendent scribbled in my file for some moments, then said briskly: "Let's try him out on a downstairs ward, see how he gets along." (171)

Once again, the recipient is provided with a perspective other than the narrator's – a psychiatrist's view – as a clue serving to figure out what really happened. The recipient can see what the author McGrath means when he states that "the reality [Dennis] establish[es] is in no way correct. It's abnormal. There is a wrongness" (cf. Falco 2007: 23).

Even if it has been mentioned that Dennis Cleg keeps information from the reader until later, one has to be aware, though, that he has no intention of deluding the reader on purpose.

12.6 Paranoia and hallucinations

Another psychiatrist, Dr. Jebb, summarises how one has come to the diagnosis of schizophrenia. The symptoms he mentions account to a major extent for the narrator's unreliability:

> "Mr. Cleg, let me see if I can sum up your career here. When you first came to Ganderhill you were a very sick boy; in fact you were displaying most of the classic symptoms of schizophrenia. You were hallucinating floridly in the visual, auditory and olfactory spheres; your affective reactions were bizarrely inappropriate; you suffered marked body delusions, you were regressed, you had ideas of persecution and thought injection." He glanced at his file. "You were aggressive on the ward and frequently had to be isolated in a safe room, in restraints. You showed no awareness of your environment, nor any awareness of why you'd been brought to Ganderhill in the first place." (187)

As far as the hallucinations Dr. Jebb addresses are concerned, the recipient is confronted with them throughout the whole novel. The narrator sees his father shrinking, hears his dead mother calling him and on various occasions fantasises about a woman living in the wall, e.g. of the cellar: "Once when I was down there in the corner I heard a voice say: 'Spider!' It wasn't my mother's voice, it was a cracked and growly voice, like an old woman's voice, and I realized it was the night-hag who lived in my wall. I didn't go

down the cellar after that." (195). Additionally, Dennis notes the presence of the creature in his room:

> I would lie awake at night and by whatever moonlight penetrated the room I would gaze at these shadowy lumps and nodules, and in my boyish imagination they became the wens and warts of some awful humpbacked night-hag with an appalling skin disease, a spirit damned for her sins against men to be trapped, tormented, in the bad plaster of an old wall in a slum. (24)

Dennis continues by addressing the horrifying dreams he experienced as a child once more. The fact that he dreams of the creature and that after waking up, she is still visible for him until his mother comes to see after the child is a further example for a dream blending in with reality and reminds one of Charlotte Perkins Gilman's short story *The Yellow Wallpaper*, which deals with mental insanity and in which the first-person narrator of the story imagines a female trapped in the wall as well.

> At times she left the wall and entered my nightmares (I was plagued by nightmares, as a boy), and then when I woke in the night in terror I would see her sneering in the corner of the room, turned away from me, her head cloaked in shadow and her eyes glittering from that horrible knobbly skin, the smell of her breath befouling the air; then I would sit up in bed, screaming at her, and it was only when my mother came in and turned the light on that she returned to her plaster, and I would then have to have the light on for the rest of the night. (24)

One occurrence involving hallucinations is especially terrifying for the young Dennis. After Hilda has moved into the Clegs' house, during dinner, Dennis discovers a blood stain in his potato: "I cut into my potato, and dead in the middle of the halved potato there was a dark stain." (117) What drives the narrator mad is that Hilda and his father behave as if everything was normal, even if – as Dennis believes - they have planned this offence on him. He is obsessed with the idea that they want to do him harm, an aspect Dr. Jebb refers to as "ideas of persecution" in his diagnosis: "It [the anxiety Dennis experiences due to that obsession] was the fear I had of my father sending me to join my mother in Canada, it was the fear of being attacked with a gardening tool at the moment I least expected it. I attempted not lo let them know what I knew but I could not sleep in number twenty-seven anymore, and I barely ate a thing, why would I? Why would I touch meat or vegetables prepared by Hilda?" (195) These statements reveal the

consequences of the paranoia Dennis suffers from, which take him as far as rejecting the intake of food and insomnia. ‘Canada’, in this context, refers to being murdered. Sometimes, by the way, he also uses this figure of speech in order to refer to the psychiatric institution Ganderhill.

Among these consequences are also the deterioration of his mental health and the hallucinations he has: “I could see them eating, their jaws moving, their eyes shining in the kitchen’s gloom, their teeth closing on pieces of food, but each feature was fixed in space separate and distinct from the rest, and it was only by combining fragments of their broken-up faces and hands that I could keep them in focus and remain alert to their activity.” (196) Dennis’s fragmentary vision of Hilda and Horace during dinner reflects the fragility of a mental state that is rapidly becoming weaker until it appears to fall into pieces.

12.7 Self-destruction

Even if Dr. Jebb’s comments on Dennis’s symptoms imply that his mental health has improved (“’My point is,” he said, closing the file, ‘that all that has changed.’” [187]), the narrator is obviously not fit to be released.

After learning about the doctor’s intention to let him go back to a life outside the psychiatric hospital, he harms himself by cutting his blood vessels:

> At about half past two in the afternoon I abandoned what I was doing (tending a bonfire of garden rubbish) and made my way up to the shed. I closed the door behind me, sat on a box, and with a knife we used for cutting the eyes out of potatoes for seeding I opened my wrists. Twenty minutes later Fred Sims found me there with my blood dripping into a flowerpot full of earth. They stitched me up in the infirmary, and by suppertime I was in a safe room on a hard-bench ward, wearing an untearable canvas gown and being very closely watched. (188)

Despite this incident of hurting himself, Dennis is released from Ganderhill, which – after having spent 20 years there - causes a feeling of consternation and anxiety: “I felt, in a

way, as I had after my mother's death – the same sense of friendless isolation in a strange and threatening world." (199)

When he arrives at the assisted living residence where he stays after having left Ganderhill, he is welcomed by Mrs. Wilkinson, who he later believes to be Hilda: "I shuffled in, exhausted and confused and very close to tears, and not for one moment did I realize who she was. It's only now that I can appreciate the implications of those first words of hers. 'We've been expecting you,' she might have said, 'so we can finish the job we started in Kitchener Street, twenty years ago." (201) The recipient receives only one of the indications that suggest that Dennis's mental instability has remained the same. He is still a paranoid and after his release his condition is quickly heading towards self-destruction, which can be observed due to a number of aspects.

Among these are Dennis's hallucinations:

> And what is it that they do? Impossible to be precise: there is chanting and stamping, also hissing, screaming, cries and shouts that are only partially intelligible, gales of laughter, voices of people I have known saying wildly uncharacteristic things: Dr. Austin Marshall reciting filthy verses for example. They use my name freely, they play on it, they invert it: gelc, they call me, gelc, and recently they invented the chant: gelc SINNED gelc sinned gelc sinned gelc sinned gelc SINNED gelc sinned gelc sinned gelc sinned … (197)

The voices seem to appear every time with more force and increasingly frequent, as between their offence he barely has time to roll a cigarette:

> They repeat it over and over, louder and louder, stamping all the while so the light bulb swings back and forth on its cord and I am plunged into shadow, then bought to lurid life, plunged into shadow, then back to lurid light – and I huddle on my chair with my legs drawn up to my chest and my head between my knees and my hands over my ears weeping weeping weeping as they push me to the very limits of what I can endure – then it breaks apart in screechy laughter – this gradually subsides, is followed by mumbling – and slowly I lift my head and catch trembling hold of the side of the table, perhaps pick up my pencil or roll a quick one while they gather themselves for the next – which *begins*, as I say, at the pitch of fiercest frenzy of the last! (197f.)

Spider transmits his story in a highly emotional way, which is gradually becoming more intense in the course of the story. This kind of style can be determined due to formal

aspects such as Dennis's fragmentary style. Apart from that, he uses repetitions such as "weeping weeping weeping" and "gelc sinned geld sinned". The exclamation mark at the end of the mad monologue quoted above underlines the emotional impact involved in his statements. The use of these punctuation marks is, by the way, perceivable throughout the whole narrative. In an incident, in which Dennis returns to his father's garden, when he is addressed by the presumably current owner, the use of the exclamation mark is even more significant as the narrator confronts the reader with an accumulation of interjections:

> Here! Here! Here here here here here here! It echoed as I turned, stumbling, toward the source, a bearded figure in a cap and raincoat on the other side of the fence. Here! Here! Here here here here here! The imps took up the cry, damn them, damn their filthy souls to hell! Oh, I fled, I went squelching and weeping back up the path and over the bridge with the sounds of their filthy voices ringing in my ears until I was back on the bench, a damp and heaving wreck, I should have known, I told myself, I should have known, they never rest, I must be cunning, I must be like the fox. (49)

The repetition of single words ("here here here") and phrases ("I should have known, […], I should have known") is striking. The word 'Oh' indicates Dennis's increased affliction as well. The voices in his head invade him to such an extent that in the end, he cannot bear them anymore and decides to commit suicide. Shortly before he rolls his last cigarette, he mentions an incident involving teeth, which represents a further intertextual signal indicating unreliability. Dennis's obsession with the dentures of a former fellow inmate at Ganderhill can be related to one of Edgar Allan Poe's short stories, *Beatrice*, which combines the obsessive attitude of the unreliable first-person narrator towards the teeth of the title character with madness and insanity.

The decrease of the narrator's mental stability is underlined by formal aspects. Towards the end of the novel, when Dennis's feeling of losing control of himself is increasing, the narrator refers to himself in the third person, as if an omniscient narrator, who has insight into Dennis's mind, had taken over:

> The days that followed grew increasingly strange for the Spider. The oppressive sense that everyone and everything around him was dead rarely left him now, and for this he knew himself to be responsible. He became aware too that a terrible catastrophe was

> about to occur, but he had no clear idea what it was or from which direction it would come. It was around this time that he decided to be buried at sea. (217)

His sensation of an impending catastrophe, which also the narrator in Kazuo Ishiguro's *When We Were Orphans* frequently mentions, is part of the paranoia he suffers from. The technique of jumping from a first-person narration to an omniscient mode stresses that Dennis (involuntarily) distances himself from his own mind and body, so that he is unable to identify with himself any more. People with schizophrenia, namely, often have the feeling that their own personality gets lost or that their own thoughts are removed while the ideas of strangers take over (cf. Alanen 2001: 42f.). The "thought patterns" (138) of others are taking possession of him, which suggests that he is the passive victim of some invading force instead of an active agent. In other words, instead of writing the story of his life himself, he is not able to free himself from the feeling of "being written" any more:

> I begin to write. And as I do a strange thing happens, the pencil starts to move along the faint blue lines of the page almost as though it had a will of its own, almost as though my memories of the events preceding the tragedy at Kitchener Street were contained not within the stubbled leather helmet of this head of mine but in *the pencil itself*, as though they were tiny particles all packed together in a long thin column of graphite, running across the page while my fingers, like a motor, provide merely the mechanical means of their discharge. When this happens I have the curious sensation not of writing but of *being written*, and it has come to arouse in me stirrings of terror, faint at first but growing stronger day by day. (134)

Even if Dennis uses first-person narration, it demonstrates a way of how Dennis's feeling of loss of control can be initiated. His adding that this feeling invades him every day more suggests that his mental fragmentation is a gradual process from which he has no chance to escape. The fact that Dennis jumps from one narrative perspective to another by integrating third-person narration along with his father's perspective as well as parts of his self that represent his father's personality or Spider's views reflects the multiple personality disorder the narrator suffers from. The increasingly frequent change of narrative viewpoints towards the end of the story indicates how fragile the mental state of the narrator is (cf. Sims 1998: 113ff.) and the limitation of his reliability as well.

Unlike Dennis Cleg, the narrator of Kazuo Ishiguro's *O* is not the typical insane narrator who is committed to an institution for the mentally ill. However, Christopher Banks's perception appears to be distorted as well, above all as he confuses dream and reality much more than McGrath's narrator.

13. *When We Were Orphans* by Kazuo Ishiguro

Born in 1954 in Nagasaki, Japan, Kazuo Ishiguro came to Britain at the age of six. He studied English, Philosophy and Creative Writing and worked for the community and as a social worker. In a postgraduate course at the University of East Anglia, he came to know Angela Carter (cf. Procter 2009), which is noteworthy inasmuch as in her works such as *The Bloody Chamber* a certain tendency towards the Gothic genre can be observed, which often integrates the unreliability of narrators, an aspect that in turn plays an important role in Ishiguro's works as well. *When We Were Orphans* is the fifth novel Ishiguro got published (cf. Procter 2009). Like Mark Haddon, one of the themes Kazuo Ishiguro is most interested in is how human minds work (Richards 2000).

When We Were Orphans is the story of Christopher Banks, or Puffin, which is how his mother tends to call him. After his parents' disappearance in their hometown Shanghai, where they have resided in a house in the International Settlement, he is sent to live in Britain with his aunt. Once he has made himself a name as a respected detective, he returns to China, which is involved in the war against the Japanese shortly before World War II, in order to find his parents and thus resolve the mystery of the crime. While he appears to be gradually getting nearer to achieving clarification, the recipient is finding themselves increasingly involved in a set of inconsistencies and confusion. These remain unsolved until the end of the narrative, when the narrator discovers that his father is already dead and that his mother has been committed to a psychiatric institution and that she is not really able to recognise her son any more. Even if the book can be assigned to the realistic genre, it surely has a whiff of surrealism as well, which makes Christopher Banks's narrative different from the one of conventional *mad monologists*, as also the author acknowledges: "I didn't want to write a realistic book with a crazy narrator. I

wanted to actually have the world of the book distorted, adopting the logic of the narrator." (Richards 2000)

13.1 General characterisation of the 'unreliable' protagonist

In Kazuo Ishiguro's *When We Were Orphans* the recipient is, likewise, confronted with a first-person narrator. It is a homodiegetic narrator who is also the main character in the narration. The reader can very clearly feel the narrator's presence, which can thus be described as *overt*. Even if he is not the prototypical mad narrator such as Dennis Cleg in *Spider,* unreliable aspects can be detected on all three of the levels discussed in the theoretical part of this paper. He can be described as an unreliable reporter as far as facts are concerned as he often doubts whether narrated events have happened in the way he depicts them or whether they have taken place at all. In addition to this, it is striking that in certain occasions he lacks the ability to evaluate these events properly, which makes him unreliable on the axis of evaluation. Finally, the reader is frequently left puzzled and questions his reliability on the axis of information as the narrator's and, consequently, the recipient's level of knowledge appears to be lower than that of the other characters in many incidents. The concept of *dramatic irony* seems be displaced and askew; often it does not grant the reader - but the other characters - information the narrator is not aware of. In contrast to *Spider,* the narrative does not allow the recipient to create their own, mostly clear alternative picture of the story. However, as it can be noted that to a certain degree, events cannot have happened as told, one can still hold the narrator unreliable due to various signals indicating unreliability.

13.2 Social situation

Even if Christopher Banks is not the loner the recipient encounters in *CID* or *Spider* at first sight, on taking a closer look, his social situation strikes the reader as ambiguous and controversial due to a variety of aspects.

On the one hand, the recipient finds that quite a part of the story consists of Christopher's descriptions of the society events he is present at. At the beginning, when an "old schoolfriend" (Ishiguro. *O*: 3) called James Osbourne introduces him to the world of influential people, he does not feel very comfortable in this environment:

> I am sure these impressions are not accurate, but that is how the evening remains in my mind. I remember standing about frozen with awkwardness, repeatedly sipping from my glass, as Osbourne chatted amiably with one guest after another, most of them a good thirty years older than us. I did once or twice try to join in, but my voice sounded conspicuously child-like, and in any case, most conversations centred on people or issues about which I knew nothing. (13)

However, he continues going to a variety of such gatherings and soon his self-assurance is increasing, thus securing himself a respectable status in society:

> During that first year after Cambridge, largely through my friendship with Osbourne, I found myself attending other smart social events on a fairly regular basis. Thinking back to that period of my life, it now strikes me as a singularly frivolous one. There were supper parties, luncheons, cocktail parties held usually in apartments around Bloomsbury and Holborn. I was determined to put behind me the awkwardness I had displayed that evening at the Charingworth, and my manner at these events grew steadily more assured. Indeed, for a time, it is reasonable to say I came to occupy a place within one of the fashionable London 'sets'. (18)

On the other hand, he does not appear to be ambitious when it comes to establishing social connexions. Right at the beginning of the novel, in the first paragraph, the narrator confesses his fondness of solitude, which he spends sauntering through the streets, reading in the British Museum or in the park: "After years of being surrounded by fellows, both at school and at Cambridge, I took great pleasure in my own company." (3) Immediately after this, he narrates about his encounter with James Osbourne, whom he invites to his flat. This is when the recipient starts perceiving him as a bit of a loner because of his reflections in connexion with his flat in Kensington, in which he has not received a visitor so far, a fact he appears to feel embarrassed about and he intends to avoid that his acquaintance notices:

> Although at that point I had yet to receive a single visitor in my rooms, I issued my invitation with confidence, having chosen the premises with some care. The rent was not

> high, but my landlady had furnished the place in a tasteful manner that evoked an unhurried Victorian past; […]. Moreover, almost immediately upon taking the rooms, I had walked over to Knightsbridge and acquired there a Queen Anne tea service, several packets of fine teas, and a large tin of biscuits. So when Osbourne did happen along one morning a few days later, I was able to serve out the refreshments with an assurance that never once permitted him to suppose he was my first guest. (3f.)

At the end of his visit, Osbourne invites him to accompany him to a party, adding that it has come to his mind to ask him as Christopher has always admired Osbourne's influential relations to people. The narrator, however, denies this by pretending not to know what he is talking about. The recipient is aware of his fake ignorance as the *narrating I* confides that he has known straight away what Osbourne had been relating to:

> My annoyance only grew once I had sat down again. I had, as it happened, guessed immediately what Osbourne had been referring to. The fact was, throughout school, I had heard it said repeatedly of Osbourne that he was 'well connected'. […] It was indeed a concept that fascinated me, this notion that he was in some mysterious way connected to various of the higher walks of life, even though he looked and behaved no differently from the rest of us. However, I cannot imagine I 'mercilessly interrogated' him as he had claimed. It is true the subject was something I thought about a lot when I was fourteen or fifteen, but Osbourne and I had not been especially close at school and, as far as I remember, I only once brought it up with him personally. (5)

The anger Osbourne's statement causes in Christopher creates the impression that he would have wished more connexions for himself and that he has, as a means of self-protection, blocked the contrast between him and Osbourne out. The following statement underlines this impression: "Nevertheless, now I look back on it, it seems probable that at least some of my fascination with Osbourne's 'well connectedness' had to do with what I then perceived to be my complete lack of connexion with the world beyond St Dunstan's." (6)

Then, Christopher continues by explaining when exactly it took place – this single occurrence in which he has spoken to him about the topic. When Osbourne notices the high degree in which Christopher seems to be disturbed by his claims, he starts a new topic. The narrator, though, keeps defending himself. Due to the integration of another perspective, the reader is challenged to find out which one is more reliable. The fact that Christopher attaches so much importance to the issue raises the recipient's doubts and

leads them to assume that it is probably the easy-going Osbourne who can be trusted more on this than the reflective narrator.

This privileged position Osbourne's view assumes in terms of reliability is supported by the fact that there are various other characters in the story whose views contradict the narrator's, which suggests that the way he describes himself is not always in line with other people's perceptions.

In one incident, for example, it is his aunt who describes him as an introverted child in spite of Christopher's preventative measure of playing at some distance to the house in order to avoid being observed: "'He's gone for hours,' I could hear her saying. 'It's hardly healthy, a boy his age, sunk in his own world like that." (10) The semantics of space underlines his aunt's observation. After the narrator has seen himself forced to leave Shanghai and his close friend Akira, he spends his time mostly on his own, immersed in the games he used to play with his mate: "This was, as I say, our basic story-line, and I suppose, incidentally, it was more or less the one I enacted over and over during those first drizzly days in England, when I filled my empty hours wandering about the ferns near my aunt's cottage, muttering Akira's lines for him under my breath." (112)

Apart from that, in terms of schoolfriends, it is not only Osbourne who has – contrary to Christopher's own views - perceived him as an "odd bird", a fact that has been pointed out in the theoretical part of this paper. Also Anthony Morgan, whom he meets again in Shanghai, addresses Christopher's isolated state at school: "'You know, we should have teamed up. The two miserable loners. That was the thing to do. You and me, we should have teamed up together. Don't know why we didn't. We wouldn't have felt so left out of things if we'd done that.'" (183) The narrator seems to remember well that Morgan has been an outsider, even before Morgan addresses the topic: "[H]is mood suddenly changed, and for the first time I saw about him a melancholy that brought to mind the unhappy and lonely boy I had known at school." (181) However, the narrator does not integrate his own isolation in these reflections:

> As I have said, I could remember well enough Anthony Morgan's being something of a 'miserable loner' at school. It was not that he was particularly bullied or teased by the rest of us; rather, as I recall it, it was Morgan himself who from an early stage cast himself in that role. He it was who always chose to walk by himself, lagging several yards behind the main group; who on bright summer days refused to join in the fun, and was to be found instead alone in a room, filling a notebook with doodles. (183)

Already when Osbourne addresses Christopher's isolation, he negates his friend's perception, remembering that he "blended perfectly into English school life", stressing his good adaptation by describing how fast he has learned the "gestures, turns of phrase and exclamations popular among [his] peers" and referring to his "two good friends of that time, Robert Thornton-Browne and Russell Stanton" (7). Similarly, his reaction to Morgan's statement that the narrator has been an outsider is incredibility and amazement: "But his assertion that I had likewise been a 'miserable loner', one with whom he might have made a matching pair, was such an astounding one, it took me a little while to realise it was simply a piece of self-delusion on Morgan's part – in all likelihood something he had invented years ago to make more palatable memories of an unhappy period." (183f.)

Even if his memories fail him on several occasions, Christopher Banks remembers Morgan's behaviour in a very detailed way. The distinction between Morgan and "the rest of [them]" demonstrates the narrator's attempt to stress the contrast between his and Morgan's position. After Morgan's supporting Osborne's memories of Christopher as an "odd bird", the narrator's claim to have been well integrated seems even less convincing. All the more, because it creates the impression that the narrator's description of Morgan's isolated state and his way of dealing with it is a reflection of Christopher's behaviour. In this sense, the recipient's assumption that he oppresses his own hurtful memories parallel to the narrator's lack of awareness creates dramatic irony.

Moreover, the integration of a further character's utterances supports the assumption that he has been perceived as more withdrawn than he has done himself. It is the view of an old acquaintance, Colonel Chamberlain, who has accompanied him on his voyage to England when he was a boy. When he meets him again as an adult, their perceptions of

Christopher's behaviour turn out to differ drastically, even if the narrator refrains from disagreeing with the old man openly. Whereas Christopher remembers himself to have been utterly thrilled about the passage to England, the colonel's statements indicate quite the opposite:

> His repeated insinuation was that I had gone about the ship withdrawn and moody, liable to burst into tears at the slightest thing. No doubt the colonel had an investment in giving himself the role of an heroic guardian, and after all this time, I saw it was as pointless as it was unkind to contradict him. But as I say, I began to grow steadily more irritated. For according to my own, quite clear memory, I adapted very ably to the changed realities of my circumstances. I remember very well that, far from being miserable on the voyage, I was positively exited about life aboard the ship, as well as by the prospect of the future that lay before me. (27)

In spite of the narrator's assurance related to the accuracy of his memories, however, during his transmission of the conversation with the colonel he also admits that several times he has acted as if he had recalled incidences where, in fact, his memories have remained blank: "He was enjoying himself and I encouraged him to do so, often pretending to remember something just to please him." (27) In this respect, the recipient can assume that part of the discrepancies between his view and the perceptions of others can also be attributed to the failing ability of his memory.

13.2 The unreliability of memory

This failure takes up considerable part of the novel. Phrases such as "I am not sure" (26), "I do not actually remember this" (24), "I do not recall" (8) and "my recollection of it is not as detailed" (9) occur frequently throughout the narrator's discourse and thus assume a kind of *leitmotif* function, representing the fallibility of the human memory. Because of the accumulation of doubts related to the accurate portrayal of events in combination with the clash of viewpoints between characters such as the colonel and the narrator, the recipient even starts to doubt the accuracy of the depiction of facts which he considers himself to remember clearly. In this respect, words that stress the reliability of the representation of incidences such as "unmistakably" (190) and "undoubtedly" (109) lose their expressive strength to a certain degree. Similarly, the reader might be sceptical

about Christopher's response to the colonel's assumption that the narrator probably does not have any memories about their first encounter: "'You know, it's funny,' he said. 'I was thinking about it, before I came out tonight. That time you and I first met. I wonder if you remember, my boy. I don't suppose you do. After all, you had so much else on your mind then.' 'On the contrary,' I said, 'I have the most vivid memory of the occasion.'" (24)

Often enough, however, the narrator explicitly admits his uncertainty. When he talks to one of the main characters, Sarah Hemmings, about a childhood adventure and, according to Christopher – presumably – other past incidents he has not communicated to anybody since his arrival in England, he adds a comment indicating the worries he has about his fading memories:

> For the truth is, over this past year, I have become increasingly preoccupied with my memories, a preoccupation encouraged by the discovery that these memories – of my childhood, of my parents – have lately begun to blur. A number of times recently I have found myself struggling to recall something that only two or three years ago I believed was ingrained in my mind for ever. I have been obliged to accept, in other words, that with each passing year, my life in Shanghai will grow less distinct, until one day all that will remain will be a few muddled images. (67)

Even if the narrator shows himself concerned about his memories disappearing in the past few years, the attentive reader will find a reflection about the narrator's failure of recollection already when he was a child: "Eventually I did settle on one memory from very early in my life, from when I could have been no older than four or five – a memory which even then, when I was nine years old, had already grown hazy in my mind." (85)

After the general utterances about his memory the narrator continues by giving a concrete example, which refers to what he has observed one morning when the health inspector of Morganbrook and Byatt, the company his parents worked for, had come in order to check on the hygienic conditions in their house. The narrator remembers witnessing an argument between the inspector and his mother about the employment of certain servants from Shantung, a part of Shanghai in which contagious illnesses and poor hygiene as well as increased theft he has claimed to be widespread. Already before the narrator starts with

his description of the incident, he utters his doubts about the correct portrayal of the details involved in the related event: “I cannot be sure today how much of my memory of that morning derives from what I actually witnessed from the landing, and to what extent it has merged over time with my mother’s accounts of the episode.” (58) Then, after the depiction of the occurrence, he refers to his uncertainty again: “[W]hile I am fairly sure I have remembered its essence accurately enough, turning it over in my mind again, I find myself less certain about some of the details.” (68) One of these details is concerned with the formulations his mother has chosen in order to express her accusations against the inspector. Another insecurity consists in the circumstantial conditions in which the event has taken place: “In fact, it is even possible I have remembered incorrectly the context in which she uttered those words; that it was not to the health inspector she put this question, but to my father, on another morning altogether, during that argument in the dining room.” (68)

In contrast to that example, on another occasion the recipient can be sure of the narrator’s correct memory of another character’s utterance, as he has a piece of evidence at his disposal. This proof consists in a note the character, Sarah Hemmings, has written to him: “I have it [the note] here now. It is no more than a scribble on unlined paper, the upper edge torn off. It is doubtful whether she gave the words much thought; it simply asks me to meet her at once on the half-landing between the third and fourth floors of the hotel.” (207)

There is no doubt about the fact that, as time passes, people forget certain occurrences, feelings and surroundings. It is a natural protective function of the brain, especially when it comes to traumatic experiences. The recipient, however, is, due to previous reading experience, also aware that usually a first-person narrator just tells his story without constantly doubting whether he depicts the true nature of events correctly. Parallel to that, as in real life, a listener will start to be suspicious about a story-teller who regularly utters uncertainties.

13.3 Low level of information

Another aspect that makes the narrator unreliable to a certain degree can be attributed to his low level of information, which leads to his puzzlement in various situations. This is related to the narrator's feeling that other characters perceive him in a pejorative way: "[W]henever such incidents occurred, I would search my memory for some offence I might inadvertently have caused the particular individual; but eventually I was obliged to conclude that such reactions had to do with something more general in people's perceptions of me." (134) The fact that he tries to think of an incident in which he might have offended the respective subject, refers to the way the narrator perceives their attitude towards him, namely as rather negative:

> It is not easy to explain how things have come to this. What I can say is that it began some years ago […] as a vague feeling I would get from time to time; a feeling that someone or other disapproved of me, and was only just managing to conceal it. Curiously, these moments tended to occur in the company of the very people whom I might have expected to be most appreciative of my achievements. When talking to some statesman at a dinner, say, or to a police officer, or even a client, I would be suddenly surprised by the coldness of a handshake, a curt remark inserted amidst pleasantries, a polite aloofness just where I might have expected gushing gratitude. (133f.)

Despite the narrator's acknowledgement that "what [he is] talking of here is so nebulous, it is not easy to recall instances to serve as clear illustrations" (134), he still tries to provide some examples. One of these refers to a conversation with a colleague during the investigation of a most horrific crime. According to the officer, when confronted with atrocities as in this situation, he sometimes wishes he had opted for a different profession. Christopher argues that closing one's eyes does not signify that malevolence disappears, though, and that thus, they have to continue fighting it, whereupon the officer reacts in a way not entirely comprehensible to the narrator:

> He remained silent for another moment. Then when he spoke again, I was rather taken aback by the hardness in his voice.
>
> 'I'm just a small person, sir. So I'll stay here and do what I can. I'll stay here and do my best to fight the serpent. But it's a beast with many heads. You cut one head off, three more will grow in its place. That's how it seems to me, sir. It's getting worse. It's getting worse every day. What's happened here, these poor little children…' He turned around

> and I could now see fury in his face. 'I'm just a small man. If I was a greater man' – and here, without a doubt, he looked accusingly straight into my eyes – 'if I was a greater man, then I tell you, sir, I'd hesitate no longer. I'd go to its heart.' (135f.)

The narrator is unsure what to make of his colleague's speech. The officer's harshness that can be directed to the evil in the world seems perfectly understandable. Therefore, at first, Christopher's assumption that the fierceness expresses the officer's feelings towards him may be interpreted as nothing more than paranoia about what other people think of the narrator. On looking closer, however, it really seems to be meant as a direct demand. It is as if the officer expected him to take action.

The most striking incident related to the narrator's low level of information occurs three or four days after Christopher Banks's arrival in Shanghai, starting with the phone call of Anthony Morgan, who is residing in the city. They agree on meeting, which is when Morgan complains about the problems he has had with his drivers and makes some – for the narrator – incomprehensive remark about his hopes that his current chauffeur will take them safely to their destination: "I had no idea what he meant by this last statement, since as far as I could recall we had not agreed to go anywhere else that night." (181) As in other incidents, the narrator refrains from asking for clarification and is – along with the recipient – left in the dark: "But I did not feel like picking him up on it, and then he had quickly moved on to telling me about the shortages afflicting the hotel." (181)

The confusion, however, does not stop there. The narrator turns out to be taken to the house where he lived with his parents during his childhood in Shanghai and in which now a Chinese family resides. When one of the residents refers to an arrangement according to which the family is supposed to return the house to Christopher Banks, the narrator is, once again, astonished. Soon however, some blurred reminiscence appears to dawn on him:

> 'The agreement? But surely…'
>
> I allowed the words to fade in my mouth. For puzzled as I was, while the young man had been translating his grandmother's words, I had started to locate some vague recollection concerning some such arrangement regarding the old house and my eventual return to it.

> But as I say, my memory of it was only a very hazy one, and I sensed that by opening a discussion on the matter I would only embarrass myself. (189)

Due to the narrator's inability to recall how it has come to the deal the man is talking about, the Chinese family's level of information is higher than the narrator's. Again, he is unwilling to act in order to gain clarity. This is when the story starts becoming every time more obscure, as if dream mingled with reality (cf. Finney 2001).

13.4 Dream and reality

One of the unreal aspects refers to a celebration supposed to take place after the narrator's achievement of freeing his parents (cf. Finney 2001). As a child, after his father's kidnapping, Christopher and his friend Akira spend a lot of time re-enacting imagined scenes involving the crime and the investigations carried out. They modify and expand the stories they act out, but the ending remains always unchanged:

> Akira and I would become the detectives – though sometimes we played ourselves – until in the end, after the chases, fist-fights and gun-battles around the warren-like alleys of the Chinese districts, whatever our variations and elaborations, our narratives would always conclude with a magnificent ceremony held in Jessfield Park, a ceremony that would see us, one after the other, step out on to a specially erected stage – my mother, my father, Akira, Inspector Kung and I – to greet the vast cheering crowds. (111f.)

The quote above is especially noteworthy as later, when Christopher, now grown-up and a real detective, returns to Shanghai for solving the case, the same aspect involving the celebration for his parents, "as if their return from captivity were a foregone conclusion" (Finney 2001), is reoccurring in Christopher's real – or is it? – world in Mr. Grayson's statement (Mr. Grayson is a representative of the Shanghai Municipal Council):

> 'Mr Banks, I appreciate this might not be the best time. But I wanted just to have a quick word. You see, sir, I've been charged with the happy task of organising the ceremony. That's to say, the welcoming ceremony.'
>
> 'Mr Grayson, I don't wish to seem ungrateful, but as Mr Mac-Donald here just put it, time is rather pressing. And I feel I've been welcomed already with so much lavish hospitality…'

> ‘No, no, sir’ – Grayson laughed nervously – ‘I was referring to *the* welcoming ceremony. I mean, the one welcoming back your parents after their years of captivity.’ (158)

At first, the detective assumes that Mr. Grayson is talking about a celebration in his honour. The representative, however, turns out to allude to a festivity for his parents, exactly how the young Christopher has imagined it with his childhood friend Akira. Not only the fact that a celebration is planned, but also that it involves the same location as in their games, is striking. The detective, however, fails to establish such a connexion, even if he is struck with the precipitate preparations:

> This, I admit, rather took me by surprise and perhaps for a second I just stared at him. He let out another nervous laugh and said:
>
> ‘Of course, it’s somewhat jumping ahead, I realise. You’ve first to do your work. And of course, I don’t wish to tempt fate. All the same, you see, we *are* obliged to prepare. […] So you see, I wondered if I could put a few very basic options before you. My first question, sir, before anything else, is if you’re happy with the choice of Jessfield Park for the ceremony?’ (158f.)

In another incident, Mr. Grayson confronts the detective once again with his plans which involve aspects such as what Christopher Banks’s speech directed to the crowd might look like and when he might give it, when his parents are supposed to appear on the platform, when the brass band might start playing and in which hotel his parents should stay. These details as well as the optimism Mr. Grayson along with other characters display concerning Christopher’s succeeding in solving the criminal case, about two decades after the investigations have failed to do so, appear highly unlikely.

Moreover, the way the story continues is dream-like (cf. Finney 2001). According to the results of his investigations, he believes his parents to be located in a house within the war zone. 20 years ago the police planned to check on it but in the end, they did not. After a Chinese lieutenant advises Christopher and provides him with directions on how to reach the specific house, he accompanies him to a certain point. There he explains that due to unclear present conditions involving the presence of Japanese soldiers in the territory of the Chinese, it would be irresponsible to proceed. Consequently, Christopher Banks continues his journey on his own. As he moves on, night falls and he makes a

sheerly unbelievable discovery (cf. Finney 2001). He identifies a wounded combatant, lying captivated on the ground, as Akira:

> I then saw in the dim red glow the figure of a Japanese soldier lying quite still on his side. His hands were tied behind his back; his feet too had been bound. His eyes were closed, and I could see a dark patch soaking its way through his uniform under the armpit further from the ground. His face and hair were covered in dust and speckled with blood. For all that, I recognised Akira with no difficulty. (248f.)

Whereas Akira's first reaction does not show any signs of recognition, then his facial expression changes and he repeatedly utters his friend's name. They continue Christopher's undertaking together, dragging themselves to the house in question, which they find without Christopher's parents present.

Not only the utter coincidence of the encounter, but also a key passage, in which the narrator voices his doubts about it in a conversation with a colonel named Hasegawa, in which he questions him about the state and whereabouts of Akira, lead to the recipient's being sceptical. The dialogue takes place in the headquarters of the Japanese, where the narrator is attended to his needs after his exhausting journey: "[A] moment later he [Colonel Hasegawa] asked in a sympathetic tone: 'This soldier. You had met him somewhere previously?' 'I thought I had. I thought he was a friend of mine from my childhood. But now, I'm not so certain. I'm beginning to see now, many things aren't as I supposed.'" (277)

It is interesting to note that all the characters involved in the episodes previously mentioned appear to participate in these unreal events (cf. Finney 2001). Kazuo Ishiguro refers to this as follows: "[A] lot of the time the world actually adopts the craziness of his [the narrator's] logic. It's not full of people doing surprised double takes when he comes out with certain statements. On the contrary, they go along with it. They all seem to support these weird notions." (Richards 2000)

They are not only optimistic as far as Christopher's solving the crime involving his parents is concerned, but they also have high expectations concerning his saving the

world form evil and from the trouble in Shanghai. This is one of the reasons why he returns to the city, even if at first he does not show himself highly confident. When he arrives there, a lady expresses her hopeful thoughts like this:

> 'Mr Banks,' she was saying, 'do you have any idea at all how relieved we all feel now that you're finally with us? Of course, we didn't like to show it, but we were getting extremely concerned about, well' – she gestured towards the sound of gunfire – 'my husband, he insists the Japanese will never dare attack the International Settlement. But then you know, he says it at least twenty times a day, and that's hardly reassuring. I tell you, Mr Banks, when news of your impending arrival reached us, that was the first good news we'd had here in months. My husband even stopped repeating that little mantra of his about the Japanese, stopped for at least a few days." (159)

Due to a variety of events in which people seem to just expect the, according to them, obvious – namely that Christopher Banks saves the world – he is in the end convinced of it as well. When Sarah Hemmings asks him to run off with her, he feels commitment to his responsibility: "'The difficulty is my work here. I'll have to finish here first. After all, the whole world's on the brink of catastrophe. What would people think of me if I abandoned them all at this stage?" (212) As in Patrick McGrath's *Spider*, the narrator appears to be paranoid about some impending catastrophe that remains without being clearly defined.

The loyalty he feels towards other people can be related to his feeling of being responsible for all evil and suffering, an aspect that also occurs in Sebastian Faulks's *Engleby*. When he tries to convince the lieutenant (who then sets off with him in order to find his parents) to send some men with him, he states: "'I know full well what you've been thinking all this time, Lieutenant! I could see it in your eyes. You believe this is all my fault, all this, all of it, all this terrible suffering, this destruction here, I could see it in your face when we were walking through it all just now.'" (245) The fact that the general evil in the world seems to represent the evil in *his* immediate world, namely the kidnapping of his parents, connected with his sense of responsibility appears to suggest that the detective feels guilty that he has not been able to help his parents in any way. This can be supported by the sense of relief he feels when it turns out that his mother has never stopped loving him. When he asks her to forgive him, she shows no signs of having

ever been reproachful towards her son: "'Forgive Puffin? Did you say forgive Puffin? Whatever for?'" (305) When his mother utters these words, Christopher begins to understand:

> '[I]t was only when she said that, it was only then I realised. What I mean is, I realised she'd never ceased to love me, not through any of it. All she'd ever wanted was for me to have a good life. And all the rest of it, all my trying to find her, trying to save the world from ruin, that wouldn't have made any difference either way. Her feelings for me, they were always just *there*, they didn't depend on anything.'" (305-306)

Although Christopher Banks does not exemplify the traditional *mad monologist*, the aspects mentioned in this analysis certainly point towards unreliability. According to the author's statement in an interview, the narrator "is perhaps not quite that sort of conventional unreliable narrator in the sense that it's not very clear what's going on out there. It's more an attempt to paint a picture according to what the world would look like according to someone's crazy logic." (Richards 2000)

In terms of conventional unreliable narrators, after Patrick McGrath's Dennis Cleg, Sebastian Faulks's narrator fits more adequately into the category again.

14. *Engleby* by Sebastian Faulks

Sebastian Faulks, the author of *Engleby*, was born in a village called Donnington, situated near Newbury in Berkshire, England. Even if he remembers himself as "shy" and a "loner", he has positive reminiscences of his childhood. Thanks to his mother, books already formed a part of his life when he was very young. After his graduation from university, he worked as a teacher and for the Daily Telegraph and various other newspapers, while spending his free time writing. *Engleby* (2007) is the novel published most recently (cf. Random House).

The novel's title refers to the surname of the main character Mike. His childhood is far from being happy: his father beats him and at school he is bullied. At university, the narrator, who states that "[o]ne of the hardest things about being alive is being with other

people" (237), develops another disturbed relationship to a girl named Jennifer. His obsession with her drives him as far as stealing her bike and going to lectures just for the sake of her presence. When one day, she mysteriously disappears, his life seems empty. However, he goes on with it, finishing college and working as a reporter. He finds a girlfriend named Margaret. Due to a panic attack he is committed to a psychiatric home. After his release, Jennifer's dead body appears and consequently, the police take up their investigations many years after her disappearance. Mike is found guilty of having killed her and, consequently, committed to Longdale Special Hospital, where the narration ends when he has spent 18 years there. The fact that during the narrative Mike assumes various identities (e.g. when he works as a journalist, at first under the pseudonym Michèle Watts and then, as Michael Watson) reflects the instability of the narrator's psyche.

14.1 General characterisation of the 'unreliable' protagonist

Like the three narrators this analysis has dealt with so far, Mike Engleby is a first-person narrator who is also the main character of the story. The narrator frequently addresses the reader with utterances such as "Does it sound as though I'm trying to keep something at bay here? Perhaps, but I don't know what." (10), which makes the recipient wonder whether the narrator hides relevant information from them, even if the character himself is not exactly aware of what. His presence is explicitly perceivable and the reader is mainly confronted with his subjective observations and reflections. Sometimes, however, the perspectives of other characters are integrated into the narration, which lead to the reader's critical reflection on the way the narrator portrays events: firstly, there are passages from Jennifer's diary, which reveal that the relationship between her and Mike is not quite as close as the narrator communicates and thus contribute to the recipient's conclusion that the main character's depiction is merely wishful thinking. Then, there are aspects, such as the evidence the police find as well as the diagnosis of the doctors responsible for Mike's treatment at the psychiatric institution, that allow the reader to elaborate on their picture of the narrator and that might help them to find out the true nature of events. Finally, the reader is introduced to what his friend Stellings thinks about Mike towards the end of the narrative. His statements include his opinion on Mike's

social situation, his relationship to Jennifer as well as his ability to handle emotions. His friend's declarations create both overlaps and discrepancies between what he and the narrator have conveyed. Stellings's comments on Mike's being a loner confirm the impressions the reader has developed from the very beginning of the novel.

14.2 The social situation

In a witness report carried out in order to help to solve the crime of the murder of Jennifer, Stellings states:

> I suppose the first er the first word you'd use if you were describing Mike is that you'd say he was a loner. He … er … at college he was always on his own, he never seemed to be with other people. In the dining hall for instance he'd quite often sit apart. He'd get his tray if it was the self-service thing and go to the end of the table and if it was formal dinner, when it was laid and you sort of had to sit next to someone, then he'd sort of take his place. But he wouldn't try to engage anyone in conversation. (279f.)

Although the narrator starts off his story by referring to his plans of going to a social event, namely the "weekly meeting of the Folk Club" (1), it becomes clear that he dislikes socialising already in the first chapter, when he talks about his first trip to college for the application procedure. He stays there overnight but refuses to have coffee at college in the morning in order to avoid the obligation of having to communicate with his fellow applicants and, alternatively, finds a location down the road: "I slept fine, but I didn't want to have breakfast in the dining hall because of having to talk to the other candidates." (3)

His aversion to eating at college continues after he has been accepted. This is why he leaves campus every now and then in order to find a pub where he has dinner. His car, which he uses in order to get to most of the eating places, represents freedom, but at the same time, it becomes a symbol for his social isolation. Mike Engleby seems to enjoy the atmosphere of especially one pub located within walking distance from college, where they offer tasty beer. There, lights are kept low, which implies that the narrator is, like Christopher Boone and Dennis Cleg, fond of being 'invisible'. The narrator also admits

that openly. Furthermore, he appears to enjoy that the barman refrains from engrossing him in a conversation despite the fact that they know each other. Occasionally, Mike also goes to a Greek restaurant, especially after having not eaten anything for a couple of days, because the servings are of considerable size. The fact that he spends days without any intake of food underlines his dislike for social places such as the dining hall. Although the narrator adds that the Greek restaurant is a kind of place "where it's embarrassing to be seen alone" (6), he obviously prefers feeling a bit uncomfortable on his own to company.

During his last year at college, he ceases eating at the dining hall completely, partly due to the cooking facilities he has at his disposal: "I have a new room this year, in Clock Court. It's got its own pantry with a gas ring so I don't bother to go to the dining hall any more." (34) In this respect, the narrator's description of his social behaviour confirms Stellings's point of view. By the way, Stellings seems to be his only, even if not particularly close, friend. After their time at college, they eat out together from time to time. In the witness report he gives to the police, his friend describes his feelings for Mike like this: "I kept in touch with him because I felt that… I … I saw something in him that I quite liked – but also I suppose out of a sense of kindness." (281)

When Mike refers to his solitary state explicitly by addressing the *implied reader*, he denies to be afflicted by it: "Have you ever been lonely? No, neither have I. Solitary, yes. Alone, certainly. But lonely means minding about being on your own and I've never minded about it." (36) What at first sounds highly assured, then turns out to lose force when he admits that he might have felt lonesome on certain occasions, such as during his travelling France: "There was something in those northern French towns, though, that did make me a bit lonely." (37) Above all, the sensations of emptiness that were invading him when he entered a church have brought about a sense of loneliness.

There are, though, also situations in which the recipient can deduce the longing for social contact and appreciation of the narrator from implicit statements. Already within the first

few pages of the novel, there are utterances underlining his need for companionship, when he fantasises about what his attending college would look like:

> I tried really hard to like the room and the college that was going to be mine. I imagined bicycling off to lectures in the early morning with my books balanced on a rack over the back wheel. I'd be shouting out to the other guys, 'See you there!' I'd probably smoke a pipe. I'd also probably have a girlfriend – some quite stern grammar school girl with glasses, who wouldn't be to everyone's taste. (2)

Later, when he works as a journalist for a Sunday newspaper, where a woman named Margaret Hudson is employed as well, Mike mentions that he is almost happy with his life, a feeling he appears to experience rarely throughout the novel. He refers to his plans of asking Margaret out for lunch, his fondness for his work and his flat being well located as reasons for his sensations. For him, happiness, however, is also linked to social interaction with friends, an aspect still absent from his life: "To wake up and feel enlivened; to be in a hurry to get out of bed and into the day. To have friends you want to speak to, compare experiences with and be on the phone to… Well, to be honest, I'm still some way from *that*." (182) That he longs for human contact can also be observed during one of his panic attacks, in which his reaction is strikingly similar to the one of Dennis Cleg in *Spider*, when one member of the staff at Ganderhill touches his shoulder and he responds highly emotionally (cf. McGrath. *Spider:* 142). Similarly, Mike's reaction implies that he is not accustomed to such acts of friendship and so he is utterly touched: "I forget what happened, except that when a man came, I wept. They brought a chair. This man put his arm round my shoulders. That's why I cried. That small kindness." (186)

Still, it is worth adding that his longing for appreciation is ambiguous. Although at first he appears to be happy about having a girlfriend, soon it turns out that too much contact irritates him: "To be honest, I also felt that working on the same paper as Margaret as well as living with her, some of the time, was becoming too much. I'd never chosen to be alone, but that was the way things had turned out, and I'd grown used to it." (232) In order to maintain his independence, he has kept his own flat while moving in with Margaret.

His relationship with Margaret does not appear to be very intense. Even if he seems to experience satisfaction to some degree, he never shows himself notably enthusiastic when he describes how he comes to know her, how they make love for the first time or how they move in together. This could be related with Dr. Exley's (one of the doctors at Longdale hospital) diagnosis of anxiety of being emotionally close to someone as well as signs of anhedonia, a disorder consisting in a "flatness of affect" (286) that also plays a role in schizophrenia: "He exhibits a degree of anhedonia – viz., he takes little pleasure in life, even in the activities that he chooses. He evinces little emotion of a positive or negative kind. He exhibits a consistent flatness of response." (286) Stellings supports this attribution of lack of emotion to Mike and adds that he has barely seen him laughing.

Part of the problematic social abilities of the narrator can probably be ascribed to the traumatic experiences he makes in a grammar school referred to as Chatfield, which he is able to attend thanks to the Romney Open - an award he has been given – that cares for the fees the school charged. At Chatfield, he basically faces two kinds of behaviour on his fellow students' part: the first kind consists in his classmates ignoring his presence throughout all their years at the school: "Being the holder of the Romney Open meant that I was placed in classes with boys a year or two older. They responded to my impertinence by not talking to me – ever. Not in all the time I was at school." (53f.) The other kind of behaviour relates to a clique of three boys, approximately 17 years of age, namely Baynes, Wingate and Hood. They reside in the Chatfield boarding-house as well and bully him. Their behaviour includes psychological terror such as threats as well as physical torture such as beating. In one incident, they open a parcel that contains a cake made by Mike's mother and his sister Julie. They tease him by fooling around with it until he withdraws to his room without the cake. In another incident they crash his radio. Apart from that, they develop a routine according to which they force him to take cold baths, which includes pushing his head repeatedly underwater until he comes out gasping for breath. For fear of facing dismissal and incredulity, Mike refrains from informing anybody of the Chatfield authorities.

14.3 Psychological disposition

What the narrator experiences at grammar school appears to traumatise him for the rest of his life. When he is invited to a dinner party at Stellings's place, upon the question of another guest who wants to know which school he has attended, he cannot even bring himself to respond by giving the correct answer: "I don't know why I told a lie. Maybe I couldn't face talking about Chatfield." (213) Moreover, he keeps avoiding eating in the canteen during his work as a journalist, as it brings back unpleasant memories of his time at school.

The impact the experiences from Chatfield has on him can also be seen in the small distance in terms of emotional involvement between the *narrating* and the *experiencing I*. The way the narrator tries to calm himself before he starts explaining how Baynes and his friends forced him into the cold-watered bath suggests that is still afflicted to a high degree, even if he tries to convey the opposite: "Baths remind me of Chatfield. Now I'll tell you what happened next. Yes. I can manage it. I'm not reliving it, I'm only describing it. I can deal with all my past experiences, I think." (68) According to narrator's utterances, he seems to be positive about his ability to deal with past events. The fact that they imply quite the opposite to the recipient creates a situation of dramatic irony and unreliability.

However, the narrator is not only troubled by his personal experiences but also by aspects that are not directly related to him: "When I was young, I used to worry a good deal." (18) He reflects about the situation in West Germany and shows himself worried about population growth, world nutrition as well as a potential future nuclear world war. Apart from that, he is worried by the life of old men who live in some institution near the place where he grows up. His occasional observations through the windows of the institution form a picture that stays in his mind and pops up every now and again, above all, because of his struggling with the idea that he is responsible for their situation: "For some reason, it was my responsibility." (21) In a conversation with his sister Julie, he tries to explain what he means by this: "'And, Jules, I feel it's my fault. When I used to see the old men

in the institution and the lights come on in the grey corridor… I feel I'm trapped in some loop…Some loop of time… I can't face coming back and being one of them next time.'" (164) He has similar feelings towards a child he has observed in a store, who has been yelled at and beaten by his mother. The reason why he is afflicted in such a way by this incident can be related to his own childhood, in which he was helplessly exposed to his father's cruel treatment and beatings. As in Ishiguro's *When We Were Orphans*, the narrator's sense of responsibility assumes pathological dimensions. After seeking medical advice due to his bad health condition, he states: "But it's bad. I feel a sort of lassitude. As well as the pain. I also feel everything's my fault. It's like how I used to feel about the old men in the poorhouse. All this stuff is my responsibility." (91) Again, he refers to his childhood observations of these old people. In this particular incident, his sense of feeling responsible may be related to his life, namely to his memories of Jennifer, as he suggests in his conversation with the doctors that his state might be ascribed to his worries "about a friend" (91). Thus, his statement could show the bad conscience he feels about what he might have done to her.

In order to relieve his troubled mind, he consumes all kinds of drugs, which also makes the recipient suspicious towards the narrator's portrayal of events from the very beginning, when he admits: "I also take drugs. I've tried most things." (6) He consumes drugs not only when he feels stressed, such as before he goes to social gatherings like the dinner party at Stellings's place, but also on a regular basis: "[I]n the evenings I tended to do what I'd always done: drink." (144) Despite this regularity and his frequent allusion to the pills he takes, he distances himself from addiction: "There are too many alcoholics in the Kestrel for my taste. What is an alcoholic? Someone who'll steal money from his only friend to buy a drink because the drink is more important and he'd rather lose the friend. I can't admire that." (16f.) Even if Mike is aware that his drug abuse causes gaps in his recollection, he obviously has no intention of stopping it: "Although I find dope gives me some memory loss, I don't really mind about that." (85) When he declares for the first time the happiness he feels in his life, or rather a feeling close to happiness, his drug consumption has decreased: "I hardly ever have to take pills any more." (181)

Due to the past that keeps haunting him, however, his mental condition deteriorates again. He suffers from more panic attacks. He already experiences the first one during his freshman year at college, after which he is committed to a psychiatric institution. What Mike still recalls from that incident is that he went to a store in order to buy a record for Julie, when, upon some irrelevant comment by the shop assistant, he fell into a state of fury. He had been familiar with the symptoms but he had not experienced them as severely as on this occasion. After washing two pills down with a considerable amount of vodka, his perception of reality began to distort. He was unsure about his existence and like Dennis Cleg, he was pervaded by a feeling of his body falling into fragments. It was as if "the centripetal force of Engleby had failed" and he "began to fly apart, into atomic pieces" (186). His fragmentary vision, applies to both himself and his surroundings: "All reality about me now appeared to be in tatters, taken down and reduced to the civil war of its particles." (186) Mike could not recall the ambulance arriving any more, which is when he had already passed out: "I remember nothing more until I awoke in a cubicle." (186)

After this incident, Mike plans stopping his madness in order to avoid a further stay in a psychiatric institution: "Tra-la. On we went. No more the madhouse." (191) Turning this plan into reality, though, is harder than he might have expected after his release. When he and Margaret go to watch a play by Harold Pinter, *The Birthday Party*, he suffers another panic attack, which makes him stagger out and enter a bar, where he takes some pills. His perception of time has become distorted:

> In panic, time stops: past, present and future exist as a single overwhelming force. You then, perversely, *want* time to appear to run forwards because the 'future' is the only place you can see an escape from this intolerable overload of feeling. But at such moments time doesn't move. And if time isn't running, then all events that we think of as past or future are actually happening simultaneously. That is the really terrifying thing. And you are subsumed. You're buried, as beneath an avalanche, by the weight of simultaneous events. (243)

The lack of reminiscence is the same as when he has his first panic attack. When he wakes up in bed at Margaret's place, he is unable to recall anything. The dialogue with his girlfriend integrates another perspective that reveals some of the details Mike lacks

reminiscence of. She tells him that he came home at about midnight with blood on his hand, that he appeared as if he had consumed lots of alcohol and that he went to bed, where he fell asleep immediately. Still, her descriptions, of course, do not give the complete picture of the evening: “The timings all made sense. The narcotic effect of the blue pills and the alcohol must have taken hold eventually. But as to what I had been doing between, say, nine-fifteen, when I felt subsumed by panic, and, say, eleven-thirty when I had found a taxi, I hadn’t the smallest idea.” (244)

Soon after his second panic attack, Mike hears the news about Jennifer’s body having been found, which is when his memories of her start haunting him with full force.

14.3 Mike’s obsession

On the first page of the novel, the reader is introduced to the fact that there is a girl named Jennifer Arkland in the narrator’s world. When he says that “there’s someone [he has] seen a few times” (1), however, this does not imply that they have a friendship or that they are dating each other, even if the narrator tries to make himself believe the opposite.

At the beginning, Mike just mentions where he has seen her and that she is a member of one of the university societies he plans to join as well. It turns out soon that he is not interested in the society itself but in her only. Most probably, he also goes to the Folk Club party just because of her. Interestingly enough, he sticks to passive observation instead of taking action by engaging her in social interaction: “I can see Jennifer and Molly and Anne, and I keep a close watch on them.” (9) He does not even attempt to start a conversation with the girl he has taken a fancy to.

Soon, Mike begins to imagine that there is more between them than in reality. Statements such as “It’s going well with Jennifer” (21) are misleading because they imply a relationship when there actually is none. During a conversation with his “moral tutor” (99) Dr. Townsend, the narrator claims to be friends with Jennifer and in several

occasions, e.g. when he talks to the police, he indicates that she is/was his girlfriend. Mike's statements are, however, set into contrast with Jennifer's diary entries, in which references to him rarely occur, and if they do, they certainly do not imply a friendship between them at all. Instead of this, she laments that a certain Simon has not left a note for her ("Check pigeonhole for possible letter from Simon [nothing: sob]" [170]) and talks about her relationship with Robin Wilson: "Still keen on R and all going well." (113) Also from Stellings's perspective they were not close:

> As far as Jennifer Arkland is concerned, er I think I knew that Mike had met her because he sort of er … gatecrashed one summer when they were making a film in Ireland, I remember him telling me about it at the beginning of it must have been our last year I think. Mike just sort of invited himself along and then … um, made himself useful. So I knew that he would have met her then and he did mention her to me I think once. He said something about that she was a friend of his. He didn't say that it was anything more than that and I certainly never saw them together. (281)

Mike becomes increasingly obsessed by the young woman. When it comes to the incident, in which he steals her bike, the fact that it belongs to Jennifer is initially kept from the reader. Although the narration provides clues that give the recipient reason to suspect that Mike has stolen it, they do not know for sure until confronted with one of Jennifer's diary entries: "When I went out on to St Andrew's Street, I found someone had nicked my bloody bike!" (194) Even if there has not been provided any explicit reference to Mike being the thief, the fact that the narrator has stolen a bike parallel to the disappearance of Jen's bicycle seems highly suspicious. After being confronted with the diary entry, the narrator alludes to a reminiscence he describes as follows:

> After lunch in the pub, I walked up Mill Lane, then up Pembroke Street. Outside Emmanuel, I happened to see Jennifer leave her bicycle in the rack and enter the college. I hung around for a couple of minutes, studying the menu in the window of the Varsity, the little Greek restaurant. Then I crossed the road, pulled her unlocked bike from the rack and rode off on it. (195)

One might think that the quote above confirms the reader's suspicions. Due to Mike's indications that he unsure about the correctness of the recollection ("I had had a memory. Was it false or true? I didn't know." [194]), it is left open whether the event has happened

in the narrator's imagination. The fact that Mike frequently steals contradicts this assumption, though.

His obsession with Jen, however, does not stop with Mike's theft. During a party at her flat, he enters her room and steals her diary, which becomes his "favourite book" (112) and which he knows by heart and soon cites with no difficulty. It even becomes something like a drug for him. Once he has returned home from Stellings's dinner party, he uses it in order to calm down: "Back home that night, I restored some sense of sanity with a diary session. I lay in bed in the darkness and selected a special date, one of my favourites: the first ever." (215)

Due to this abnormal relationship with the young woman, the recipient immediately considers a connexion with Mike as soon as the narration reveals Jennifer Arkland's disappearance. When the narrator communicates how he has come to know that she has gone missing, he demonstrates ignorance and denies having any knowledge about what has happened to her: "[S]omething truly terrible has happened. It's very hard for me to believe or think about it in any cogent way. […] Nobody told me about it, as I feel they should have done. It was barely even 'news' by the time I heard it, having been known for almost twenty-four hours." (86) That nobody has informed him about the incident supports that his close relationship with her was nothing more than imagined.

Not until much later, when Mike is supposed to return to college for professional reasons, does he provide the reader with a detailed description of what might have happened in a night – as the narrator claims - a fortnight before Jennifer's disappearance. At first, he tries to talk his superior, Tony Ball, out of obligating him to go back to his former college. His boss does not give in, however, and so Mike soon finds himself on the way there. Before the narrator reveals any details about the journey's consequences, he prepares the reader for the affliction revisiting his past has brought to him: "It was almost twelve years since I'd been there and I was not prepared for its impact on me." (224) Then he starts describing his recollection:

> But it wasn't that night, the night of Jen's Last Walk, the reconstruction, that came back to me.
>
> It was a night exactly two weeks before, at exactly the same hour. For the first time since the day itself I seemed to have a clear picture of what had happened. I don't know if it was a memory of fact; but it was certainly a coherent version of events. (228)

The narrator continues by describing how he has waited in his car after a party until Jennifer has left the house in order to offer to take her home, which she has acceded to politely. After trying to prolong the drive as much as possible, his reminiscence stops at a point where he has been about to drop her off in front of her house:

> Then… And then I had no further memory – if memory is what it was.
>
> The recollection – no, I can't call it that – the narrative, the sequence of events that had come into my mind, was all quite clear up to the point we crossed the Cam. I could play and replay it and it never varied. I remembered every word she said, the inflection of her voice, the super-friendly relaxation with which she overlaid her slight anxiety.
>
> But at the moment the front wheels of the 1100 were north of the water – nothing. (230)

The way he talks about his memory as if it was a DVD player is similar to Christopher Boone's machine-like description of his memory in *CID*. However, the gaps that remain as well as his uncertainty about the "sequence of events that had come to [his] mind" – as he calls it, rather than memory – illustrate the narrator's unreliability along the axis of facts. Once Mike has achieved a routine in his life that includes his work and his girlfriend, he feels as if his life was going two ways: one way consists in these regular, predictable daily activities whereas the other one relates to the indiscernible memories he is, like Dennis Cleg, haunted by:

> I felt that my life was on two paths. There was the one I knew about and understood […]. But then there was the second path or strand, which I didn't understand at all, and I felt this was principally because I couldn't remember parts of it. Here I was with a memory that others assured me was freakish in its recall of facts and dates and long passages of writing; yet actions and events in my own past that really should have been able to remember themselves without prompting from even a workaday, let alone a Rolls-Royce, memory – they weren't there. They were not only unstored, unregistered, not indexed; it was as if these things had never happened.
>
> So perhaps they hadn't. (253f.)

This nebulous aspect of his memory is what Mike refers to when he states that in contrast to other people, who "were in sunlight", he "was in darkness" (255). The inability to see clearly reflects his lack of understanding of what happened in his past. Gradually, however, more memories come back to him until he finally ends up with a description starting with how he gave Jen a lift in his car to his beating her to death and burying the corpse. His depiction is characterized by an emotionally distanced style, which supports his attitude towards emotions: "[I]n the end that's how everything that happens to you feels: it feels like nothing at all, really." (64) Utterances such as "I think" and "I don't remember" (275), which underline his uncertainty, pervade his portrayal of events. According to the police, however, he is guilty, which they have proved by taking the DNA from blood they have found on one of Mike's T-shirts and comparing it to Jennifer's: "We were having a DNA match done in Leicester. It takes them ages. But we got the results yesterday. The bloodstain on your tee shirt is a match with the DNA from Jennifer's bones.'" (268)

In addition, the narration integrates the perspective of one of the narrator's psychiatrists, whose diagnosis is that Mike has a schizoid personality disorder. According to his notes, he does not doubt that his patient has murdered Jennifer. However, he does not believe him to be the murderer of Baynes and a stranger called Gudrun Abendroth, which the narrator believes himself to be as well:

> Although he has suggested otherwise, I am not convinced that the patient is responsible either for an assault on a schoolmate that may have led, indirectly, to his premature death many years later, or the murder of a German woman in London, in which case no forensic evidence survives, the victim's body having been flown home and cremated.
>
> I suspect that the patient believes that a diminished responsibility plea stands a better chance of succeeding if there is more than one crime. (290)

The assumption that Mike takes on the responsibility for having killed the two other people in question so that he will be better off in court does not imply, though, that he has deceived the reader on purpose. As with Jennifer's case, he is not sure about his being the murderer.

The novel concludes with a further depiction of what might have happened the night when Mike gave Jennifer a lift. It appears in the form of Jennifer's diary entries. The passage describes how she has invited him for tea at her place and that finally she has offered him to pass the night there:

> Closed curtains again. Finished tea. Put J. Mitchell *Ladies of the Canyon* very softly on my small record player, got into bed, put arm round Mike and fell asleep again at once, hearing the rain beat down outside.
>
> For some reason dreamed of sparkling Greek sea, Aegean blue, with wooden boats, their white sails filled with love. (342)

These utterances introduce a totally new perspective of what could have happened. Appearing at the end of the novel, the recipient is probably not willing any more to accept a version that differs from Mike having murdered Jennifer, due to all the aspects that have been analysed so far such as his unstable psychological condition, the evidence found by the police and his obsessive behaviour. However, the passage cannot be dismissed as easily as Mike's wishful thinking either, despite the likelihood that this is what it can be described as. The reader is left pondering about what has really happened in Mike's past; above all, because he introduces this last passage from Jennifer's diary – or an imitation? – with which the novel ends, as follows: "There are some things in the past that may have happened and some that may not have happened. But the reality of their happening or not happening *then* has no weight *now*. Until we can navigate in time, I'm not sure we can prove that what happened is real." (340)

15. Conclusion

As this analysis has shown, the personalities of unreliable narrators can vary significantly from one to the other. In this particular investigation, they range from characters with Asperger's Syndrome to narrators with a personality disorder and mental illness and storytellers who appear to be 'normal' at first sight but in reality suffer from the loss of memory and fail to differentiate between dream and reality. However, numerous of the

characteristics representative in the narrative of one character reoccur in the discourse of the other narrators and thus create an interwoven collective picture of unreliable traits.

To sum up, Patrick McGrath's narrator Dennis Cleg can clearly be identified as the most typical example for unreliable narration. He can be considered the archetypal *mad monologist*, who finds himself lost in a net of confusing memories and whose discourse portrays a number of the signals usually found in unreliable narratives. He is a loner who shuts himself off from his environment, while at the same time he appears to long for social understanding and contacts. In this respect, his diary compensates his social isolation to a certain degree. Dennis suffers from a mental illness that involves all kinds of hallucinations ranging from the visions he has to his belief that the thoughts of others conquer his mind. He is plagued by paranoia and ideas of persecution and has a distorted way of perceiving events, due to which he also fails to interpret them correctly. The confusion he experiences is reflected in his discourse, marked by high emotional involvement and frequent reader address serving to convince the recipient of his version of the story. The signs of mental confusion as well as the distorted perception of events, however, cause a distance between him and the reader and lead to their construction of an alternative account of the story.

After McGrath's *Spider* it is Sebastian Faulks's *Engleby* that shows most of the signals characteristic for the narratives of *mad monologists.* In the same way in which Dennis Cleg's discourse obsessively focuses on a significant past event involving the homicide of his mother, Mike Engleby desperately attempts to reach clarification concerning the murder of the subject of his obsession, Jennifer Arkland. The narratives follow the same structure in that the narrators constantly switch between a present story level and the past. Both stories end with the characters' failure at making sense of their memories. When it comes to *Spider*, however, it is probably a little bit less challenging to find out the real happenings, as in the end, the recipient is left with a proof identifying the narrator as the killer. By contrast, *Engleby* ends with a clue, which leads the reader to think exactly the opposite for a moment, even if it does not really make them reconsider and part from their conclusion that Mike is responsible for the young woman's murder.

The story of the narrator Christopher Banks in Kazuo Ishiguro's *When We Were Orphans* is different from *Spider* as well as from *Engleby*. Unlike the other two narrators, Christopher is never committed to an institution for the mentally ill and neither can he be considered a suspect concerning a murder although a criminal case is also involved in this story, namely the disappearance of his parents. However, the personality of the narrator is strikingly similar to Dennis and Mike in many aspects. First of all, despite his trying to prove the opposite, in reality – if, according to nowadays epistemological scepticism, there is something like that - he is immersed in his own world in the same way as McGrath's and Faulks's narrators. Also as far as his unreliability of memory is concerned, he is in no way better off. In contrast to Dennis's obsession with his father and Mike's obsessive attitude towards Jennifer, Christopher Banks is obsessed with his striving to save his parents and the world. When the facts are stated that Dennis confuses real life with his nightmares and that Mike tends to lack the ability to distinguish between his imagination and how things really are as well, there has to be added that the boundary between 'fact and fiction' is much more blurred in Faulks's narrative and thus represents one of the novels main themes. In contrast to *Spider* and *Engleby*, in *When We Were Orphans* the concept of an ultimate truth gains even more importance and leaves the recipient with the finding that there is no such thing.

Mark Haddon's novel is not so much about ultimate truths; it rather centres on different kinds of perception. In this respect, it might be more appropriate to call a character like Christopher Boone 'narrator with an alternative perception' (without any judgements that make 'common' perception superior) than unreliable. However, his depiction also fits into the category of unreliability as he exemplifies the type of unreliable narrator that has a naïve way of interpreting the world and thus fails to evaluate the true nature of events properly. Due to his child-like evaluation, the recipient has no difficulties detecting the interpretations of certain events he can probably not be so much relied on. Aspects found in conventional unreliable narratives such as social isolation including peculiar character traits in dealing with people as well as stylistic examples illustrating emotional distance and perceptive distortion can also be detected throughout the novel.

Although the delusions of the narrators are not intentional, all four of them illustrate the nature of unreliable narration pretty well. However, one also has to be aware that what a character talks about when and from which angle is always subjective to a certain degree, which in a way makes recipients find themselves inside curious minds in all narratives. Nonetheless, as in *When We Were Orphans*, this thesis cannot answer the question about an ultimate truth either.

16. Deutsche Zusammenfassung

Diese Arbeit beschäftigt sich mit Formen unzuverlässigen Erzählens in zeitgenössischen englischen Romanen. Bei unzuverlässigen Erzählern handelt es sich gewöhnlicherweise um Ich-ErzählerInnen, die eine Wahrnehmung der Welt haben, die zu Diskrepanzen zwischen ihrer Interpretation und der der Rezipienten/Rezipientinnen führen kann. Auf diese Weise wird der/die LeserIn herausgefordert, seine/ihre eigene, „wirkliche“ Version der Geschichte zu kreieren, deren sich der/die ErzählerIn in der Regel nicht bewusst ist.

Nach einer Definition unzuverlässigen Erzählens setzt sich die Arbeit mit möglichen Zwecken dieser Erzählform auseinander. In Hinblick darauf, dass literarische Unzuverlässigkeit bereits in Werken des 18. und 19. Jahrhunderts eine Rolle gespielt hat, obwohl der literarische Terminus der Unzuverlässigkeit erst 1961 geschaffen wurde, folgt eine kurze Bezugnahme auf die historische Entwicklung dieses Konzepts. Diese erstreckt sich von dem Aufkommen von Romanen in der Ich-Form, einhergehend mit Auffassungen von Subjektivität, über die moderne Tendenz, nach der es keine endgültigen Wahrheiten gibt. Im Anschluss daran wird der Übergang von traditionellen Definitionen unzuverlässigen Erzählens als literarische Kategorie zu einem neuen Bewusstsein überblicksmäßig behandelt, bevor zwischen diversen Formen unterschieden wird, die unter anderen Faktoren davon abhängen können, wie absichtlich die verzerrte Darstellung der literarischen Wirklichkeit erfolgt. Um eine willkürliche Zuschreibung von Unzuverlässigkeit seitens des/der Rezipienten/Rezipientin zu verhindern, wird danach auf spezifische textuelle Signale, die den Diskurs unzuverlässiger Erzähler häufig prägen, verwiesen, sodass eine intersubjektiv nachvollziehbare Analyse möglich ist. Diese Signale beziehen sich auf die soziale Isolation des/der Erzählers/Erzählerin, dessen/deren hohen Grad an emotionaler Involviertheit in dem narrativen Geschehen und dessen/deren Unfähigkeit, Ereignisse aufgrund dessen/deren Naivität adäquat zu interpretieren und werden dem Weltwissen der Rezipienten/Rezipientinnen entgegengesetzt.

Ebengenannte Aspekte spielen eine wichtige Rolle in den Romanen, die als empirische Grundlage in dieser Diplomarbeit dienen. Diese sind: *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* (2003) von Mark Haddon, *Spider* (1990) von Patrick McGrath, *When We Were Orphans* (2000) von Kazuo Ishiguro und *Engleby* (2007) von Sebastian Faulks. Die Resultate der Untersuchung zeigen, dass die Persönlichkeiten von unzuverlässigen Erzählern/Erzählerinnen signifikante Unterschiede aufweisen. Sie umfassen eine literarische Figur mit Asperger Syndrom, Erzähler mit einer Persönlichkeitsstörung oder einer psychischen Erkrankung ebenso wie eine narrative Instanz, die auf den ersten Blick ‚normal' erscheint, wo sich aber bald Gedächtnisverlust und die Unfähigkeit, zwischen Traum und Realität zu unterscheiden, zu erkennen geben. Viele der Charakterzüge eines Erzählers kehren allerdings im Diskurs der übrigen Figuren wieder und so ergibt sich ein vernetztes kollektives Bild erzählerischer Unzulänglichkeiten, das sich über die vier Werke spannt.

Zusammenfassend lässt sich sagen, dass sich in dieser Analyse der Erzähler Dennis Cleg in *Spider* von Patrick McGrath als der repräsentativste unzuverlässige Erzähler klassifizieren lässt. Er ist der archetypische *verrückte Monologist*, der sich in einem Netz aus verschwommenen Erinnerungen gefangen sieht und in dessen Diskurs sich viele der Merkmale wiederfinden, die für unzuverlässiges Erzählen charakteristisch sind. Er ist ein sozialer Außenseiter, der sich allerdings gleichzeitig nach Zuneigung sehnt. Sowohl inhaltlich als auch stilistisch spiegelt sich die Konfusion der Figur wider. Diese Verwirrtheit zusammen mit der verzerrten Darstellung der Realität veranlassen den Leser/die Leserin, seinen/ihren eigenen Verlauf der Geschichte zu entwickeln.

Nach *Spider* von Patrick McGrath lassen sich in *Engleby* von Sebastian Faulks die meisten Indikatoren für unzuverlässiges Erzählen ausmachen. In gleicher Weise, in der sich die Darstellung Dennis Clegs zwanghaft um ein bedeutungsvolles vergangenes Ereignis rund um die Ermordung seiner Mutter dreht, versucht Mike Engleby verzweifelt sich Klarheit zu verschaffen, was seine Erinnerungen an den Mord von Jennifer Arkland, dem Subjekt seiner Besessenheit, betrifft. Die Romane folgen der gleichen Struktur insofern, als die Erzähler immer wieder zwischen einer narrativen Ebene der Gegenwart

und der Vergangenheit hin und her springen. Außerdem enden beide Diskurse mit dem Scheitern der Figuren in ihrem Streben nach Erkenntnis.

Der Erzähler Christopher Banks in Kazuo Ishiguros *When We Were Orphans* unterscheidet sich in gewisser Weise deutlich von Dennis und Mike. Im Gegensatz zu ihnen landet Christopher nie in einer Institution für psychische Erkrankungen und wird nicht verdächtigt, einen Mord verübt zu haben, obwohl auch in dieser Geschichte ein Kriminalfall involviert ist, nämlich das Verschwinden seiner Eltern. In mancher Hinsicht ähnelt die Persönlichkeit des Erzählers aber auffallend den Charakteren von Dennis und Mike. Er lebt in gleicher Weise in seiner eigenen Welt und auch was die Zuverlässigkeit seines Gedächtnisses betrifft, erweisen sich Unzulänglichkeiten. Außerdem hat Christopher ebenso Probleme damit, zwischen Einbildung und Wirklichkeit zu unterscheiden, ein Aspekt, der einen wichtigen Platz in der Geschichte einnimmt. In *When We Were Orphans* erscheint die Frage nach einer endgültigen Wahrheit noch zentraler als in den anderen Werken und sie hinterlässt den Rezipienten/die Rezipientin mit dem Gefühl, dass so etwas nicht existiert.

Bei Mark Haddon steht nicht so sehr die Thematik einer endgüligen Wahrheit im Vordergrund, sondern vielmehr geht es um unterschiedliche Formen, die Welt wahrzunehmen. Was Christopher Boone, den Erzähler in *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time* von seinen Mitmenschen unterscheidet, ist die spezielle Perspektive, mit der er seine Umwelt betrachtet. Aufgrund der naiven Art und Weise, wie er Vorkommnisse interpretiert, ergibt sich eine verzerrte Darstellung. Diese zieht sich durch den gesamten Diskurs der narrativen Instanz, zusammen mit anderen Aspekten charakteristisch für unzuverlässiges Erzählen wie soziale Isolation und charakterliche Eigenheiten in seiner Auseinandersetzung mit den anderen Figuren.

Obwohl die Täuschungen der Charaktere nicht absichtlich geschehen, veranschaulichen alle vier narrativen Instanzen, denen sich diese Diplomarbeit widmet, was unzuverlässige Erzähler ausmacht. Allerdings ist zu beachten, dass das, worüber eine Figur (oder auch ein Mensch im wirklichen Leben) wann und von welchem Gesichtspunkt aus spricht

immer subjektiv gefärbt ist, was dazu führt, dass sich Rezipienten/Rezipientinnen zu einem gewissen Grad immer in kuriosen Denkweisen wiederfinden. Eine letzte allgemeingültige Wahrheit kann jedoch auch in dieser Diplomarbeit nicht gefunden werden.

17. Bibliography

Primary sources

Faulks, Sebastian (2007/2008). *Engleby.* London: Vintage.

Haddon, Mark (2003/2004). *The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time.* London: Vintage.

Ishiguro, Kazuo (2000/2001). London: Faber and Faber.

McGrath, Patrick (1990/1991). *Spider.* New York: Vintage Contemporaries.

Secondary sources

Alanen, Yrjö O. (2001). *Schizophrenie: Entstehung, Erscheinungsformen und die bedürfnisangepaßte Behandlung*. Stuttgart: Klett-Cotta.

Allrath, Gaby (1998). "'But why will you say that I am mad?'". In: Ansgar Nünning, ed. *Unreliable Narration: Studien zur Theorie und Praxis unglaubwürdigen Erzählens in der englischsprachigen Erzähllliteratur*. Trier: WVF.

Attwood, Tony. *The Complete Guide to Asperger's Syndrome.* London, Philadelphia 2008. [Online]. http://books.google.com/books?id=qJZmsp3ZVG8C&printsec=frontcover&dq=attwood+tony+the+complete+guide&hl=en&ei=oWJJTJvOBtKJ4Qb_pqWaDA&sa=X&oi=book_result&ct=result&resnum=1&ved=0CCcQ6AEwAA#v=onepage&q&f=false [2010, May 18].

Berger, Jutta (2010, July 14). “Eine anders gestrickte Wahrnehmung der Welt”. *Der Standard*. MedStandard: 15.

Bläß, Ronny (2005). “Satire, Sympathie und Skeptizismus: Funktionen unzuverlässigen Erzählens.” In: Fabienne Liptay/Yvonne Wolf, eds. *Was stimmt denn jetzt? Unzuverlässiges Erzählen in Literatur und Film.* München: edition text + kritik, Richard Boorberg.

Booth, Wayne C. (1961/1983). *The Rhetoric of Fiction.* Harmondsworth: Penguin.

Busch, Dagmar (1998). „*Unreliable Narration* aus narratologischer Sicht: Bausteine für ein erzähltheoretisches Analyseraster“. In: Ansgar Nünning, ed. *Unreliable Narration: Studien zur Theorie und Praxis unglaubwürdigen Erzählens in der englischsprachigen Erzählliteratur.* Trier: WVF.

Chatman, Seymour (1978). *Story and Discourse: Narrative Structure in Fiction and Film.* New York: Cornell University Press.

Chatman, Seymour (1990). *Coming to Terms: The Rhetoric of Narrative in Fiction and Film.* Ithaca, London: Cornell University Press.

Falco, Magali. *A Collection of Interviews with Patrick McGrath.* Paris, 2007. [Online]. Èditions Publibook.
http://books.google.com/books?id=yqQFx5KLGiMC&pg=PA26&dq=unreliable+narration+%2Bspider+%2Bpatrick+mcgrath&lr=&cd=1#v=onepage&q&f=false [2010, Aug. 3].

Finney, Brian (2001). “Figuring the Real: Ishiguro's *When We Were Orphans*”. *California State University.* Published Essays.
http://www.csulb.edu/~bhfinney/ishiguro.html [2010, Aug. 13].

Fowler, Roger (1977). *Linguistics and the Novel.* London: Methuen & Co Ltd.

Fludernik, Monika (1996). *Towards a 'Natural' Narratology*. London, New York: Routledge.

Fludernik, Monika (2009). *An Introduction to Narratology.* Abingdon: Routledge.

Haddon, Mark and Dave Weich (2003, June 24). "The Curiously Irresistible Literary Debut of Mark Haddon". *Powell's Books.* Author Interviews. [Online]. http://www.powells.com/authors/haddon.html [2010, July 22].

Haddon, Mark and Simon Crompton (2006, Sept. 23). "Inside a Curious Mind". *The Times.* Archive Articles. [Online]. http://www.timesonline.co.uk/tol/life_and_style/health/features/article647138.ece [2010, July 23].

Harker, John W. (1989). "Information Processing and the Reading of Literary Texts." *New Literary History* 20.2: 465-481. [Online]. http://han.uni-graz.at/han/31383/www.jstor.org/stable/469111?seq=9 [2010, June 18].

Holcombe, Garan (2004). "Mark Haddon." *British Council.* Author index. [Online]. http://www.contemporarywriters.com/authors/?p=auth3E38026813f8c194E5NnW1CF3087 [2010, June 18].

Hrushovski, Benjamin (1984). "Fictionality and Fields of Reference: Remarks on a Theoretical Framework." *Poetics Today* 5.2: 227-251. [Online]. http://www.jstor.org/stable/1771931?seq=17 [2010, June 18].

Koebner, Thomas (2005). "Was stimmt denn jetzt? 'Unzuverlässiges Erzählen' im Film." In: Fabienne Liptay/Yvonne Wolf, eds. *Was stimmt denn jetzt? Unzuverlässiges Erzählen in Literatur und Film.* München: edition text + kritik, Richard Boorberg.

Pfister, Manfred. *The Theory and Analysis of Drama*. Cambridge 1988. [Online]. CUP. http://books.google.com/books?id=2BxOGkheiHMC&printsec=frontcover&dq=the+theory+and+analysis+of+drama+pfister&hl=en&ei=YRMaTOL3FteisQb1tpzhBw&sa=X&oi=book_result&ct=result&resnum=1&ved=0CCgQ6AEwAA#v=onepage&q&f=false [2010, June 17].

Menhard, Felicitas (2009). Conflicting Reports. *Multiperspektivität und unzuverlässiges Erzählen im englischsprachigen Roman seit 1800*. Trier: WVT.

Nischik, Reingard M. (1991). *Mentalstilistik: Ein Beitrag zu Stiltheorie und Narrativik. Dargestellt am Erzählwerk Margaret Atwoods.* Tübingen: Gunter Narr.

Nünning, Ansgar (1997). "'But why *will* you say that I am mad?' On the Theory, History, and Signals of Unreliable Narration in British Fiction." *Arbeiten aus Anglistik und Amerikanistik* 22.1: 83-105.

Nünning, Ansgar (1998). „*Unreliable Narration* zur Einführung: Gründzüge einer kognitiv-narratologischen Theorie und Analyse unglaubwürdigen Erzählens". In: Ansgar Nünning, ed. *Unreliable Narration: Studien zur Theorie und Praxis unglaubwürdigen Erzählens in der englischsprachigen Erzählliteratur*. Trier: WVF.

Olson, Greta (2003). "Reconsidering Unreliability: Fallible and Untrustworthy Narrators." In: *Narrative* 11.1: 93-109.

Phelan, James and Mary Patricia Martin (1999). "The Lessons of 'Weymouth': Homodiegesis, Unreliability, Ethics, and *The Remains of the Day*". In: David Herman, ed. *Narratologies: New Perspectives on Narrative Analysis.* Columbus: Ohio State University Press.

Procter, James (2009). "Kazuo Ishiguro". *British Council*. Author Index. [Online]. http://www.contemporarywriters.com/authors/?p=auth52 [2010, Aug. 8].

Richards, Linda (2000). “January interview: Kazuo Ishiguro”. *January Magazine.* Profiles and Interviews. [Online]. http://januarymagazine.com/profiles/ishiguro.html [2010 Aug. 13].

Rimmon-Kenan, Shlomith (1983). *Narrative Fiction: Contemporary Poetics.* London, New York: Routledge.

Sims, Dagmar (1998). “Die Darstellung grotesker Welten aus der Perspektive verrückter Monologisten: Eine Analyse erzählerischer und mentalstilistischer Merkmale des Erzählertypus *mad monologist* bei Edgar Allan Poe, Patrick McGrath, Ambrose Bierce und James Hogg.“ In: Ansgar Nünning, ed. *Unreliable Narration: Studien zur Theorie und Praxis unglaubwürdigen Erzählens in der englischsprachigen Erzähllliteratur*. Trier: WVF.

“Sebastian Faulks: Biography”. *Random House*. Biography. [Online]. http://www.sebastianfaulks.com/index.php?page_id=3 [2010, Aug. 16].

18. List of abbreviations

Primary Sources

CID = The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time

O = When We Were Orphans

Secondary Sources

A = Allrath 1998

N = Nünning 1998